

Block**3****ONLINE JOURNALISM**

UNIT 9**Basic Elements of Online Journalism**

UNIT 10**Writing for Online Media**

UNIT 11**Online Newsroom Setup**

UNIT 12**Content Production: Online Media**

UNIT 13**Production of News Website**



UNIT 9 **BASICS ELEMENTS OF ONLINE JOURNALISM**

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9.0 INTRODUCTION

Online journalism refers to content created and distributed online. In other words, this is a type of journalism which operates via internet. Online journalism should not be confused with ‘citizen journalism’. Online journalism is publishing of information that is equivalent to that of its print and broadcast counterparts (such as newspapers, magazines, radio and television). It follows the professional code of conduct similar to traditional journalism. This is how it differs from citizen journalism, which is not bound by any ethical and professional code of conduct.

Digital media is a technology-driven and evolving medium. New innovations, new ideas and concepts are added to it more frequently than in any other traditional media. The introduction of mobile telephony has made access to news a universal

phenomenon. In India, there are more than a billion mobile phone users with over 389 million having access to internet on their handsets. According to a report by Internet and Mobile Association of India (IAMAI, 2017), the number of internet mobile users is expected to double in the coming years. These days, more and more people are using mobile phones to access news and multimedia content. For a better user experience, most media organizations are making their websites responsive.

A responsive website is one which appears the same on all devices including the desktop, tablets and mobile handsets irrespective of their operating system. The mobile has assumed such a central stage in digital communication that organizations have now adopted 'mobile-first' concept. It means a website is designed and developed keeping in mind the mobile handset users instead of the earlier priority which was given to the desktop.

9.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After working through this Unit, you will be able to:

- understand the characteristics and features of online journalism;
- know about the works of online journalists and prevailing trends in online journalism;
- comprehend the status of online journalism in India; and
- gain an insight into social networking sites for online journalism.

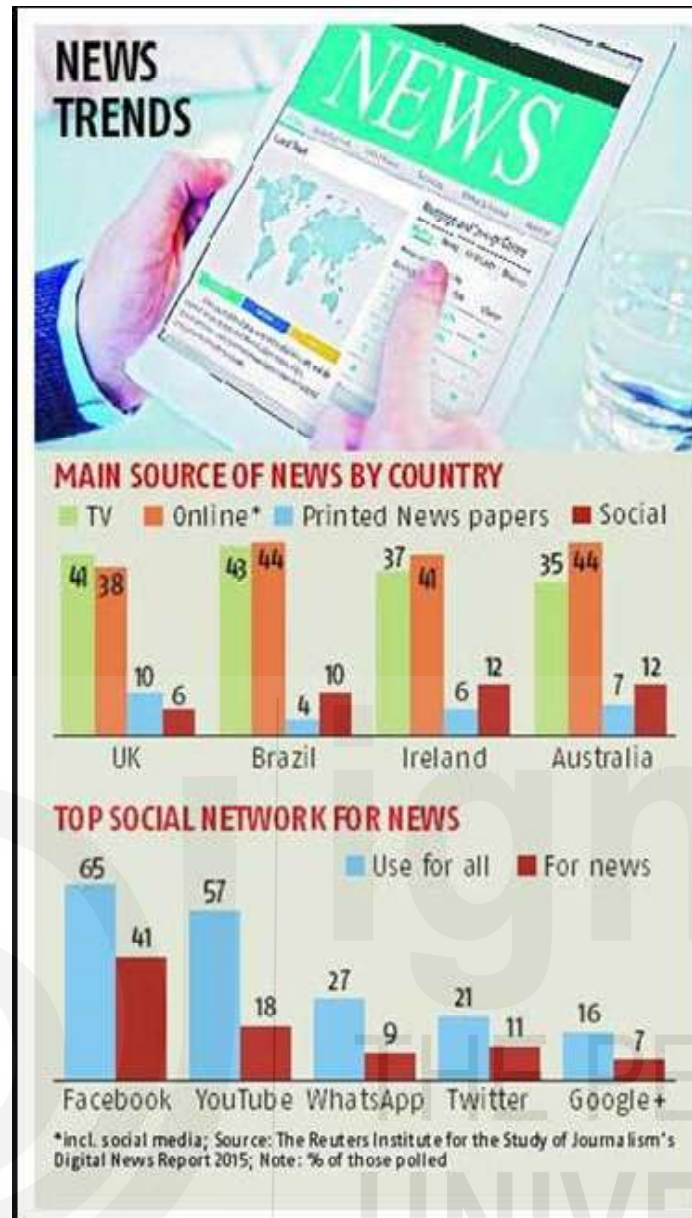
9.2 UNDERSTANDING ONLINE JOURNALISM

With a few clicks, you can now access almost the entire world of journalism and its vast variety of sources along with multimedia materials. Before we delve deeper into multimedia or online journalism, let us understand a few definitions and keywords. Holly defines online journalism as original writing and reporting that are delivered via the World Wide Web.

Today as we are witnessing that all types of work is getting transferred onto the online mode, the media industry has also not lagged behind but has ventured deeper into it and is exploring new opportunities of online news delivery and related online news businesses. In the prevailing atmosphere of cut-throat competition in the news industry, those news organisations who are not adapting the online medium are expected to lose their competitive edge and may be unable to sustain for long.

You must have experienced that while trying to search for any reading material, picture or video on internet, as you write certain keywords in the search engine you get results running into several hundreds of web pages. Sometimes these links get you on to a blog, many times on to a news website and occasionally to government websites. All these links do not belong to online journalism. Only, websites belonging to media houses or blogs created by professional journalists for providing authentic information to their readers can be categorised as online journalism. Actually, in recent times you might have noticed that the line between professional and personal journalistic writings are blurring significantly, mainly due to proliferation of social media and its popularity.

The online medium provides journalists with a vast range of options to gather information in an interesting and entertaining way. The internet provides opportunity for instant publishing, archiving, linking, use of audio and video with greater interactivity and also provides instantaneous feedback. All these features give online journalism an upper hand over other media. These key features of online news medium has a great impact on conventional media e.g. newspaper, radio, and television. Online medium is not only posing a challenge to the conventional media but is also forcing them to adopt changes in their newsroom operations and news delivery platforms.



The impact of this can be seen in most daily newspapers as they have begun to use more box items and bulleted information. This is only to make the newspapers easy to browse. Renowned page designer Mario Garcia was engaged to re-launch one of the prominent newspapers in India in the recent past. In a briefing, Gracia suggested that page should be designed in such a way that it should be easy to browse. The broadcast medium also tends to use the interactive and feedback features of online medium. If you listen to radio you will find that the radio jockey asks you to make your song choice online. And TV news channels are using online poll, and particularly many prime time discussion shows are incorporating feeds from live discussion on social media.

This raises an important question - whether the new media can be seen as a threat to conventional media or not? This is a point of debate among scholars. Some believe that online medium will replace conventional media as it has all the qualities of traditional news media. Here in online medium, you can read text, listen to audio and watch video at your convenient time and pace. But others believe that various types of media will continue to co-exist and the online medium will complement all others. Even at present different types of media exist together. However, there are growing examples from the west where print editions are

getting significantly reduced in size while correspondingly their digital media presence is growing. In India, the current scenario is quite different. We are witnessing a unique scenario where on the one hand, print editions are growing in the regional languages and equally online journalism outlets are expanding

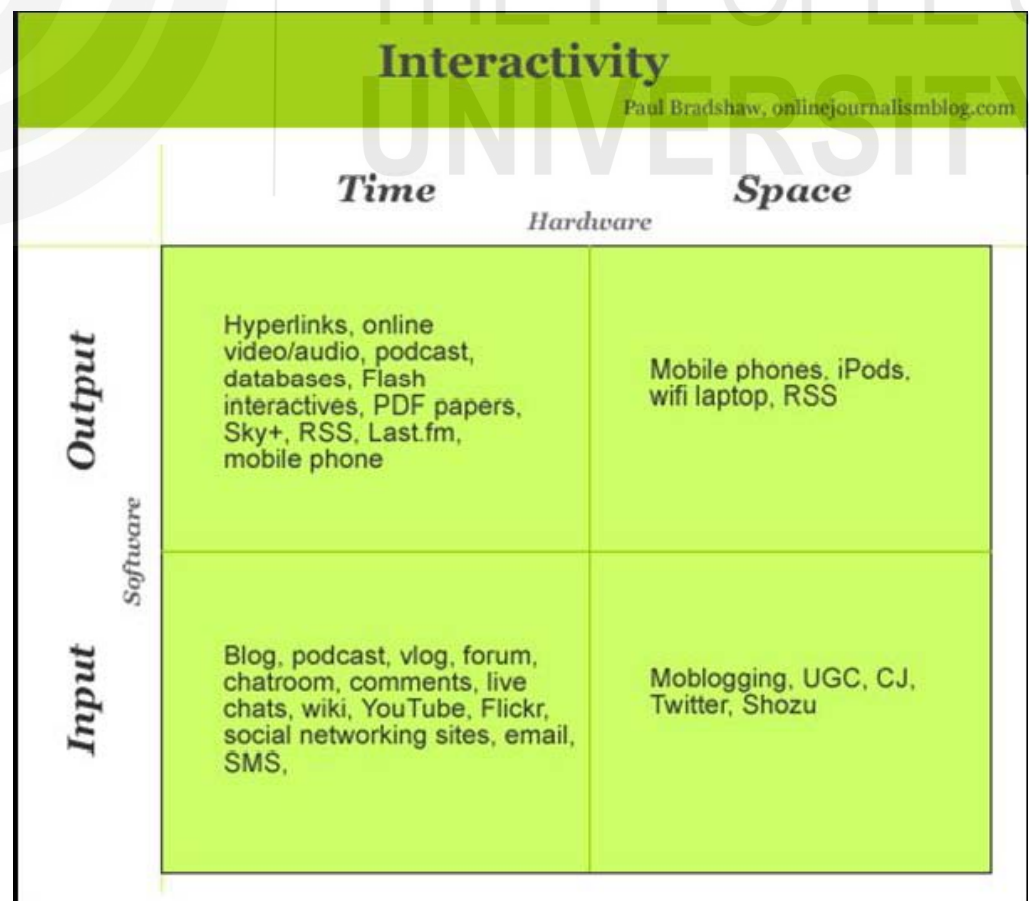
9.3 CHARACTERISTICS OF ONLINE JOURNALISM

You have learnt the key features of online journalism; now let us understand the important characteristics of online journalism.

Online: As the word suggests, it operates on a online platform which can be seen or updated in real time. Here breaking news and events can be updated as it happens - like live telecast in television news channels, live updates in news websites are quite common nowadays. While we have had this facility in Radio and TV also where we gather around and take updated information, the difference here is that it can be seen on your computing devices and even hand-held gadgets like mobile with some added features.

Shifted time: Online journalism also takes advantage of shifted time. Online publications can archive stories for now or later. Users can read those stories at any time of their choice. In other medium this facility is not available easily. In the conventional print media, if you want to read any previous day's or month's newspaper you have to get access to the news organization library or one should collect newspapers on daily basis and archive it periodically – which can be quite a tedious task.

Multimedia: Online journalism can include multimedia elements: text and graphics (newspaper and books), sound, music, motion elements and



animation.(broadcast medium), 3D, etc. One of the greatest opportunity of multimedia journalism is the ability to combine various media elements for a news story. At present, most media organisations provide derivatives of their ‘parent’ products. Newspapers are providing digital text, radio organisations are providing audio clips and TV channels are providing streamed video links. But multi media is providing to these news entities an opportunity to adapt other designs also. There are number of sites where we can see this adaptation. Now radio channels are not only providing audio files but also complementing them with images and texts - the All India Radio (AIR) and the Voice of America (VoA) websites are testimony to this.

Newspaper organisations are not only providing digital text but also audio clips and motion pictures - almost all major dailies are practicing this method. TV channels are also complementing their video files with text – similar to newspapers all leading news channels are running their news portals. Seizing this opportunity, online sites are now trying to take full advantage of the array of media formats available. Websites are now complementing a story with flash animation, photo gallery, video and audio clips.

Interactivity: Online journalism is interactive. Hyperlinks are primary mechanism for this interactivity on the web. Through hyperlinks different types of media options are added to a news package to bring more in-depth analysis. Through hyperlinking various elements of lengthy and complex works are added together in a story. Work of an online journalist consists of hyperlinking of own web pages or at times links to other websites.

Interactivity also provides users options to comment and add some information to the existing content. Online sites also conduct online poll to bring in more.

Interactivity. This feature of online journalism is helpful in several ways:

- It makes users’ spend more time on the web page.
- It makes the users’ experience more enjoyable.
- It helps users to gain more information.
- Users perceive the site navigation easily.

Immediacy: As per Encyclopaedia of Journalism, ‘News is like bread-it is best served fresh as it goes stale quickly.’ This statement points to the fact that immediacy is a key component of journalism. Journalists have responsibility to provide information as quickly as they can and what better way to do it than through the internet. It is the fastest medium and through this information can be disseminated from personal computer to mobile. With the ability to upload content anytime through a basic internet connection, online media is as immediate as we can get.

But then the question arises-whether immediacy wins accuracy. What can be the priority? As we know on the internet, information can be uploaded by any individual on any social networking site or a blog. Individuals cannot be expected to be guided by professional ethics and code of conduct applicable to organizations. In this scenario, any wrong information uploaded can create a chaotic situation. Hence, it is important for online users to know how to find reliable information.

Hyper-textuality: Hyper-textuality is a prime ‘tool’ used to introduce interactivity in a web page. Hypertext is a web link which can be used to provide variety of information in one page. These links carry a variety of media content (audio, video, graphics, animation , etc.) in a story. Through hypertext, journalists enrich their content. So, this being a distinctive unique characteristic of online journalism, it helps differentiate online media differently from other forms of media. Traditional journalism provides for linear presentation of a story while online media brings multi-linearity to the story. It also enables users to be participants when they click their way through hyperlinked set of pages.

Check Your Progress: 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) List three usages of hypertext in a news story?

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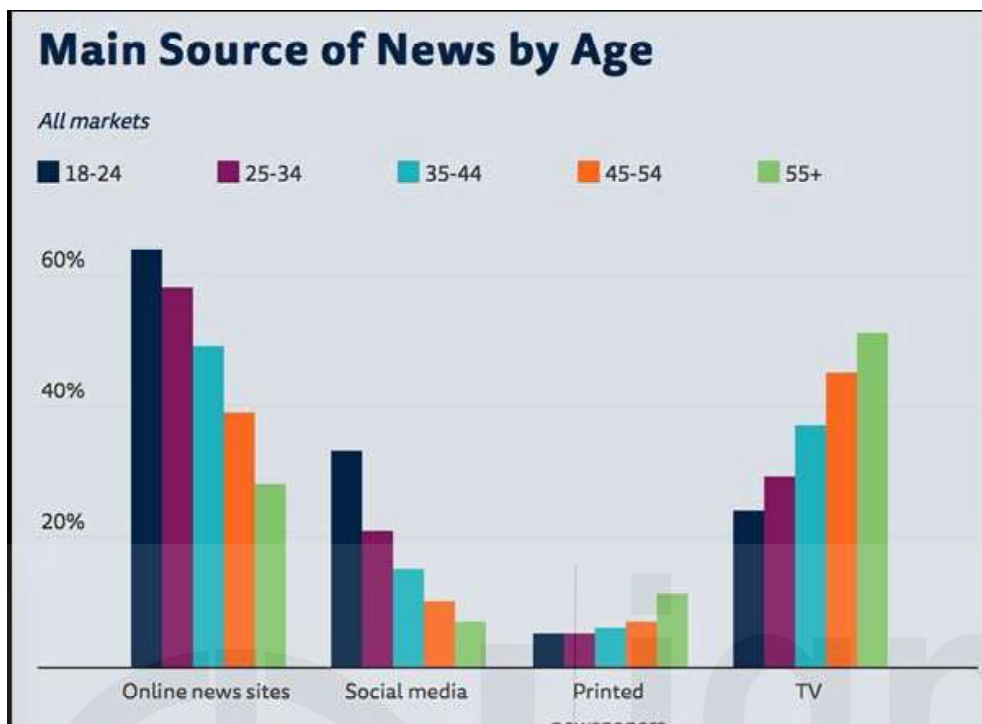
9.4 REPORTING FOR ONLINE NEWS MEDIA

The impact of online media has been so huge that even reporters of conventional media have begun to use online tools for reporting. Journalists take news lead from social media pages and uncover the story. For this purpose, they keep following various personality profiles on the social networking and micro-blogging sites.

We now come to another platform - a citizen blog. People from diverse backgrounds have their own personal blog. They keep writing on a variety of issues. Some blogs carry people’s comments on an issue which is popular in mainstream media but some are really important from the reporting point of view. For example, many known personalities keep sharing their experiences on blog and even their viewpoints on certain subjects which also carries news value. Journalists keep following their blogs in order to get lead from there.

There are also examples where journalists are referring to blogs for news coverage. The importance of blog was understood during the Iraq war, when journalists were denied open access to most parts of that country with a camera. Even at that time some journalists managed to send real time information from the war torn zone. Another interesting case is from the USA. The news stories on Monica Lewinsky were first exposed in a blog named drudgpost.com. This was a blog of a journalist who, upon his organisation declining to take up that story in print, was forced to post it on his blog and the rest, as they say, is history. The point here is that the enormous potential reach of such social networking sites can be tapped as a good resource for reporting which the journalists are doing regularly these days. Online reporters have yet another challenge in that they have to involve readers in the reporting also. Here journalists do not have any other option.

Interactive features of the internet has inherent potential to involve the readers and it becomes the responsibility of an online journalist to facilitate their desire. There are three ways of online reporting.



9.4.1 Traditional Reporting

In the traditional reporting method, the online reporter uses online tools in traditional ways like interviews, observation, looking through documents, reading online and aggregate opinion. The only difference here is that all these news collection activities are carried out through online. By using e-mail or chat they take interviews, journalists keep browsing different websites and make observations, they read online documents and finally create a story by aggregating opinion.

9.4.2 Open Source Reporting

Traditionally reporters do not share the story idea with their readers while investigating and finding facts in the field. Reporters do not want to lose a potential scoop to their competitors. But reporters in the open source reporting take the opposite route. They share their story idea beforehand and ask users to share their opinion, information and source. After getting information, reporters go through all information provided and come up with a final story. However, it is not mandatory that all the information provided by readers will be used in the final story. It is up to the reporter to use his/her discretion and judgement regarding the information provided/collected.

The open source reporting is based on participatory theory of communication, which is based on the belief that the group knows more than an individual. Open source reporting suggests opening up the reporting process to engage a community of readers in making a report, which will give more information, more analysis than a single reporter. This type of reporting is best suited for small media organisations with limited resources.

9.4.3 Distributive Reporting

Distributive reporting takes open source reporting one step further by relying on readers to submit information. Here, the community itself adds the multi-faceted body of work, often covering all angles of the story. It is done especially in stories which affect a large population. For example, the US geological survey's "did you feel it?" earthquake shake maps, where people posted their personal experiences. Another example is the Flickr collections of readers' photographs having same tags.

This type of reporting is helpful in covering a story which has a huge impact and which affects a large population. In such a case, the possibility of readers having first-hand information is more likely and through distributive reporting all possible information can be tapped easily.

As distributive reporting involves readers in story formation it increases the responsibility of a journalist. If it is not handled properly it would turn into anonymity, with fake reports and defamation. But keeping the participation theory in mind, this can turn into the best way of reporting if the readers' identities are checked properly. Journalists have to design this kind of reporting effectively. Distributive reporting can generate a large volume of information in a fraction of the time.

Check Your Progress: 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

- 1) How is reporting for online news medium different from reporting for conventional media?

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- 2) Compare and contrast the open source reporting and distributive reporting.

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9.5 PROFILE OF ONLINE JOURNALISTS

Many people consider online journalism as their dream job, but to become an online journalist you need to have skills of a reporter, editor, designer and other skills which are related to the internet medium. Prior to understanding the profile

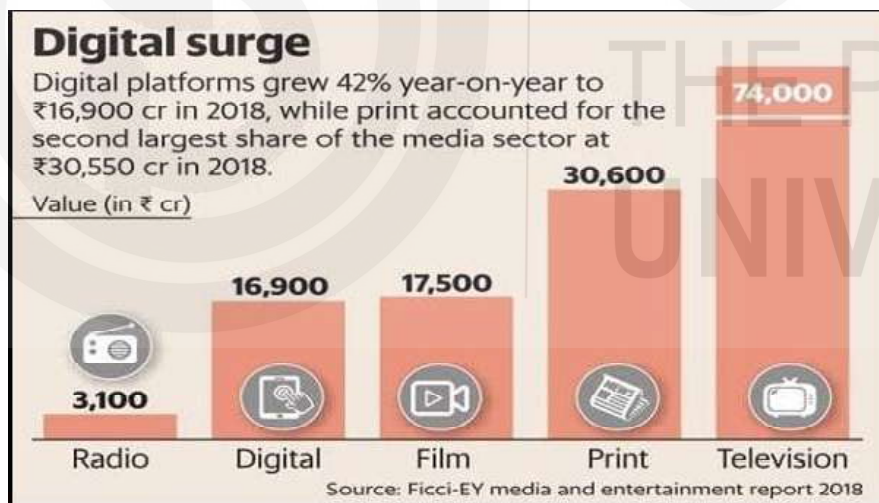
of an online journalist, it is necessary to understand the various dimensions of online journalism. Online journalism broadly covers three dimensions: integrated production, multi-platform delivery and multi skilled professionals.

9.5.1 Integrated Production

Online contents are created in multimedia format, that contains the combination of any one or more of the following media elements - text, graphics, pictures, audio and video with interactive features. This is carried out by different departments. It also covers video editing, audio editing, designing and text editing. All these departments work together to come up with a final product. Integration between all these departments is very necessary for quality work. Whereas in the print media, all departments work independently and the level of integration is pretty low.

9.5.2 Multi-Platform Delivery

Online contents are delivered through different platforms. Online readers may access contents on personal computer and mobile also. Sometimes they subscribe to social networking platforms to get regular updates. Online journalists need to be ready for multi-platform delivery. Contents created for personal computer would be different from contents created for mobile. Updating social networking page is equally important. While digital technology has made multi-platform delivery much easier but it is important to note that regular human intervention is needed to improve the quality of content. In integrated production every story can be originally produced to fit different platforms at the same time.



9.5.3 Multi Skilled Professionals

To undertake multi-faceted work, the online medium needs multi skilled professionals. The work of an online journalist can be broadly divided into six parts:

Provide quality work: Internet has made working easy for the journalists. Here everyone can do it. It is a challenge for good online journalists to perform well and provide quality work with the help of various internet tools.

Showcase work: After coming up with a quality work, the next challenge is to showcase the work to potential readers. There are several ways in which journalist work can be disseminated. Through the choice of right method to showcase the

journalist can greatly enhance the readers experience. Work can be shown through written text, multimedia, using picture galleries and graphics.

Interact with readers: Online medium offers great potential for interactivity. Here journalists can talk to their readers in real time. As an online journalist, one should ask the readers what they do not know and after assessing their need should work accordingly. Online journalist should always try to engage the readers on their turf, never try to preach to them and also help the readers to engage meaningfully amongst themselves. They should let the readers reach a journalist when they wish and also facilitate interpersonal communication by providing contact email or social media ID to the readers.

Help readers to get the complete picture: In online medium, there is always a possibility that users may not be able to assess the desired information or they may get one sided information or incomplete information due to lack of background information. An online journalist should always try to practice responsible sustainable journalism. It can be done by recycling and reusing of the background information. Make sure to provide relevant background information through a hyperlink and also make it easily searchable.

Plan well for story: Make a list of story assets. Then make a list of descriptions of the types of readers who will be interested in the story. Then try to find a path which will suit every reader. Storyboarding is important as it helps to frame the story efficiently.

Be poised at the time of breaking news: At the time of breaking news try to be the first but never forget to cross check the information from different sources. Always remember, giving no information is better than providing wrong information. At the time of breaking news, journalist should be ready to take information from the readers. Tell the readers what the journalist know so far and allow them to give the some more information related to the story if possible.

To complete such a diversity of work in the online field requires multitasking professionals in the newsroom. In other words, more number of professionals in the newsroom who can do more than their normal share of work. A multimedia journalist would develop editing, reporting, design and other skills. Hence, three levels of multi-skilling is required of an online media professional:

Media multi-skilling - it means the journalists capable of producing content for different media;

Issue multi-skilling – they need to report on news related to different thematic areas. It means a journalist covering crime should also feel comfortable covering politics also.

Technical multi-skilling - they are responsible for performing most of the production task. For example, reporters may need to do editing work and if needed work as multimedia professionals also.

Check Your Progress: 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) State the qualities of multi-skilled professionals in online journalism.

9.6 TRENDS IN ONLINE JOURNALISM

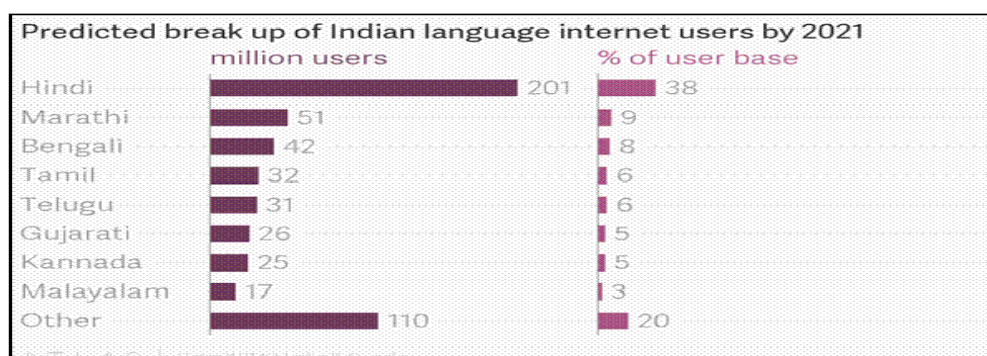
With new technologies in the digital world cropping up every day along with the changing desires of users it is creating new trends in online journalism. These trends are not only helpful in tapping more users but also in providing new experiences to users.

9.6.1 Time Shift Journalism

The days when we waited for re-telecast of a programme on television are over. Similarly, we do not have to make arrangements for individual recording of some popular show. Because now in the age of internet, all we need to do is to search the internet for the content and watch it at our convenience. The reason is simple, now it is time for time shift journalism or time shift content. Also the time when we first encounter an information and finally the time we consume it can be different. That is why the tab like 'read later' or 'watch later' have become quite common.

9.6.2 Emergence of New Digital Platforms

In order to meet the consumers demand, new technologies are emerging and giving opportunities of new experience of news. Emergence of several new devices like tablets and smartphones are becoming very challenging for online journalism. Compounded with this challenge is the increasing number of operating systems, for example, there are two major types: iOS, and Android in the mobile market. Basically, these new devices are changing the way that we consume news. Online media houses have to be compatible with these changing technologies. Many media houses are coming up with new applications to meet these challenges. But as the product life cycles are getting shorter and shorter in this digital age it is finally up to different news organisations and other online entities to try and figure out how they can produce the kind of product that will fit into these sorts of niches.



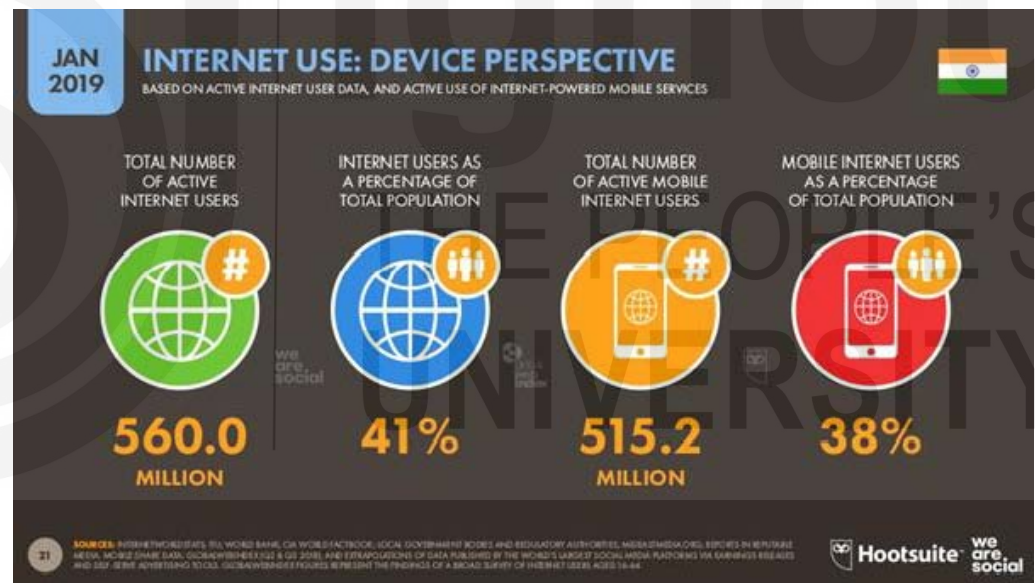
9.6.3 Web 2.0 is Taking Lead

Web 2.0 is the new talking point in online media. It enables users to play an active role in content creation. In the world of web 2.0, content power is not with media but with the masses. Web 2.0 provides the basic structure of participation, such as:

Architecture of participation: these are online facilities for user generated content such as .blogs, and wikis. The popular website based on web 2.0 is Wikipedia, where every registered user can contribute/edit/delete the content as per the existing Wiki community norms.

Crowd sourcing: this is a collaborative form of reporting where with the help of web 2.0 a group of people work together to gather information. Each contributor researches on a part of the overall piece.

The premise is that the group knows more than an individual at any point of time and new technologies are enabling such an effective form of collective and collaborative action. This is encouraging citizens to take active part in this new form of journalism. Besides, this will strengthen the democratic process as Beth Simone Novech argues that the way people are coming together, not just to create content, but also to create power.



9.6.4 Publishing Online has Become Easy

Publishing online has become easy with the advent of many online platforms and new technologies. Publishing content on blogs and social networking sites has become very common and popular among youth. On social networking sites too, the youth are dominating. Another new thing which is becoming common among youth is 'mobile phone blogging'. This is location based instant blogging. They use their camera to shoot or click a photograph and post it instantly. It has made online journalism more competitive. Now the success of a website does not only depend on the quality of its own content but also on the gathering content online by following online platforms like blogs, micro blogging websites and social networking websites.

By using these facilities websites following web 2.0 are trying to elicit more participation from its readers. These websites focus on submission of users, rather than staff reporters or editors. Such contents are gathered from a variety of online options: blogs, photos, podcast, video sharing, reviews, forums, etc.

9.7 ONLINE JOURNALISM IN INDIA

The history of the internet is very short in India. It started in 1995 when Videsh Sanchar Nigam Ltd (VSNL) introduced internet in six cities in India. The first cyber cafe in India was launched in 1996 in Mumbai and in the same year rediff.com was launched. The first Hindi web portal in India named Webdunia was launched in 1999.

As of December 2018, India had 566 million internet users, which is about 40% of internet penetration (Kantar IMRB, 2018). Out of these users, 493 million were active internet users. If we further bifurcate the data, 293 million users were from urban and 200 million from rural areas. And as we all are aware that the Indian government has been trying to push internet access to the Panchayat level and has been also promoting computer literacy in the rural areas to implement the e-panchayats programme. In such a scenario, it is obvious that the number of internet users in rural India will go up manifold in the coming years.

Hence, the future of internet journalism looks bright in India. More penetration of internet is bound to bring more users. So internet journalism in the country should be well prepared to serve the needs of people from different classes. Looking at the current situation however, it seems that internet has to cover a long way.

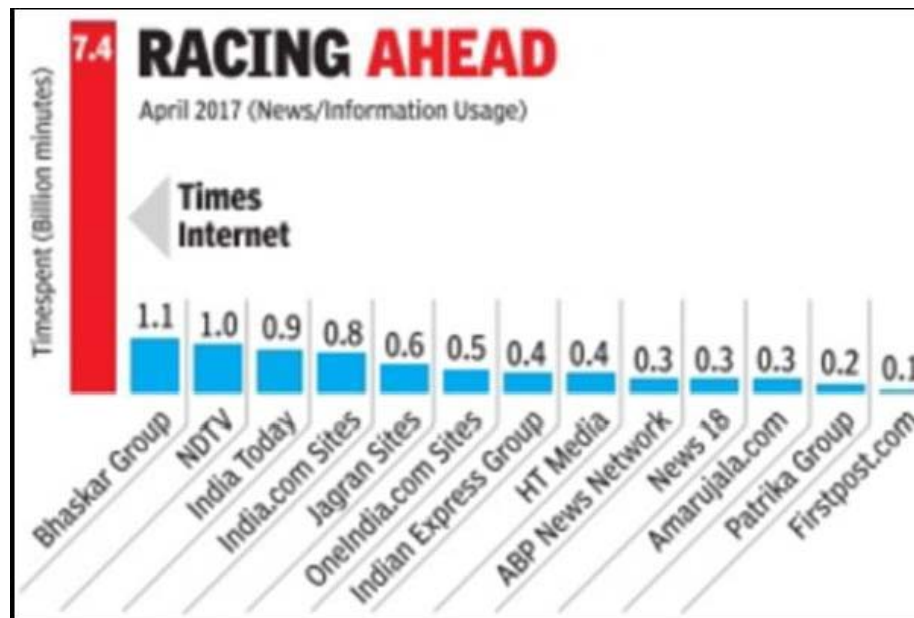
9.7.1 News Websites in India

Many news websites in India seem to be mere extensions of the prime media product (Newspapers or News channels) itself. Websites are created to carry detailed stories of a wide range filed by the reporters and editors of the newspaper. Quite a few independent sites are also operating, but their economic base is not very strong. Because of that limitation, they are unable to hire trained online journalists. They are still fully dependent on agency feeds and newspapers reporters. Many news channels have also their websites. Courses related to online journalism are not taught in various institutions.

9.8 SOCIAL MEDIA FOR ONLINE JOURNALISM

Social networking sites provide online space where people can create their online profiles and update it with their activities. While doing so they can keep track of updates of their friends and family.

People can also engage in group activities and display feeds information to their home page. These feeds range from personal to news stories.



For journalists and news organisations it is a platform which can be used to connect with people to share and receive as much information as they can. Journalists can use this platform in the following ways:

- Online journalists can showcase their stories here. It is a platform where journalists can develop personal brands of themselves.
- Online websites can create their own page on social networking sites to share some of the important stories there. With help of this, a website can increase its traffic.
- Social networking sites can develop widgets and applications to give important news feeds customised to individual needs and demand. For example, hindustantimes.com has developed a special page named 'I love my Delhi' where they keep posting important news and activities in Delhi.
- Journalists can develop their own network to get information and some lead to an incident and make a comprehensive story. There are several examples where the news organisations received the first information through social media.
- Online news websites should not always try to post links only, they should also try to share something as small write-ups. This will be helpful in brand building.

9.8.1 Some Important Social Networking Sites

According to Alexa ranking (a popular online website ranking website) the top three social networking sites are listed below:

Facebook: Facebook founded in 2004, initially started as a service for college students but soon opened for everyone. As on June 2019, worldwide it had 2.4 billion monthly users (Facebook Newsroom, 2019).

Twitter: Twitter was launched in July 2006. It has become synonymous with social movements in many countries. Public figures seem to prefer this medium as it helps them in keeping in touch with their audience directly. In 2018, globally there were 321 million monthly users in Twitter (Washington Post, 2019).

LinkedIn: It was launched in 2003. It is a network site which targets professionals and promotes itself as a platform where one can make business contacts and find jobs. In October 2019, globally there were 645 million users in Linked In (Linkedin Newsroom, 2019).

9.8.2 Blogs and Citizen Journalism Websites

Blog is an area with a separate identity. In India, the news value of blogs is very limited. Here, a majority of blogs are expression of personal opinion by the blogger or commentary on a certain issue, which can be highly subjective and biased.

Citizen journalism is an area where a person works on a report and puts it on the public domain. But in India this area in a very nascent form and has a long way ahead. At present various news sites give them a separate specific designated space named citizen journalists.

9.8.3 Business Concern

It is also a well known fact that globally online journalism has created its own niche space and it has made advertisements switch over. During the recent global melt down, while many newspapers in western countries got badly affected, the internet remained unaffected. Publishers in developed countries are debating over the adverse effects of internet over print business. But in India the scenario is quite different. Here, the circulation of some newspapers is increasing. Print managers are exploiting the new information and communication technologies and expanding their businesses. Many leading newspapers have come up with their local editions like Hindustan, Amar Ujala, Dainik Jagaran (Hindi newspapers), Hindustan Times, Times of India, the Telegraph (English newspapers) and so on. More and more readers are showing interest in local editions.

Print editions are also adopting new marketing techniques to tap more readers. Among the new marketing techniques are organising events and exhibitions for readers and offering gifts and discounts to subscribers. Such techniques seem to be increasing the visibility and circulation figures of the dailies. Hence, the print medium seems to have responded well to the changed circumstances. It has adopted the new technologies and increased its circulation. Statistics has shown that more and more readers are now preferring regional language newspapers (IRS, 2018) and that may be one of the driving factors for many local edition of several newspapers coming up. Yet another factor could be the growing literacy rate among rural population.

9.8.4 Prospect of Online Journalism in India

Under these circumstances there is tussle between print and electronic media for greater portion of the advertisement pie. The online medium has not received priority yet. Advisers are willing to consider web edition to insert advertisements just as add-on in some of the websites of leading newspapers. This means that the web edition does not make substantial revenue to run a successful website.

Check Your Progress: 4

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What is the present status of online journalism in India?

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9.9 LET US SUM UP

In this Unit, we have discussed the key features of online journalism and its characteristics. We discussed the reporting format for online news media and methods for online story construction.

We came to know about the profiles of online journalists and trends in online journalism. Also, we discussed online journalism in the Indian context and the way of using social networking sites for online journalism.

9.10 KEYWORDS

Interactivity: is a kind of communication process that occurs between human being and computer systems. Based on a user's engagement, the computer respond to his/ her demands, usually online media content is displayed based on a click/tap.

Scanability: the level ability or skill for a person to read a portion of text. In online media, it refers to user's glancing through web content simultaneously scrolling the webpage.

WEB 2.0: it refers to second stage of development in internet, mainly it denotes the changes in users' engagement with the internet (user generated content) and emergence of social media.

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9.12 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress: 1

- 1) It is available online and can be archived for easy access with added features of multimedia, immediacy and hyper textuality.

Check Your Progress: 2

- 1) While creating online story one should try to make readers feel more informed, entertained and engaged. For that scanability and compact pages for online story should be ensured. Also, the story should have multimedia, tags/keywords, hyperlink based structure and interactive features.
- 2) Here in online news media all reporting processes are done online e.g. by using email and chats, interview is done, different websites are browsed to make observations. Open source reporting and distributive reporting are the main features of reporting for online news media.

Check Your Progress: 3

- 1) Multi skilled professionals in online journalism provide quality work, showcase work in right way so that readers gain great experience, interacts with readers, help them to get complete picture of the story, plan ahead for the story and are poised during breaking news online.

Check Your Progress: 4

- 1) Many news websites are mere extensions of the prime media product (Newspapers or News channels) itself. Websites are created to carry detailed stories on a wide range of issues filed by reporters and editors of the newspapers. Many independent sites are also operating, but their economic base is not very strong. Because of that they are unable to hire trained online journalists. They are still fully dependent on agency feeds and newspapers reporters. Many news channels have also their websites. But that is also to carry popular video clips on the websites.



UNIT 10 WRITING FOR ONLINE MEDIA

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- 10.10 References and Further Readings
- 10.11 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

10.0 INTRODUCTION

In the preceding Unit we learnt about how the digital media has transformed our approaches to access news and information in the twenty-first century. As more and more people are now equipped with internet-enabled smart phones, digital devices have become the primary source for all our communication needs. According to Reuters Institute India Digital News Report 2019, around 68% of the respondents surveyed cited smart phones as the primary source for accessing online news. The increasing use of mobile phones has led to a considerable change

in the media ecosystem. As a result, the demand for online media content writers has assumed greater significance on digital platforms. Also, the change in media technologies has given birth to new terminologies in the digital space. For example, the editorial team whose major responsibilities are collecting news and editing it are now called 'content generators'. Likewise, reporters and sub-editors in the online media have been transformed to 'content writers' and at senior position as 'content manager'. This is largely because news and editorials are now seen more as a marketable product on the digital space.

As digital space proliferates, it needs more and more content, to feed the ever-expanding medium. You would have known from your experience that writing for online media is increasingly becoming a very specialised skill with its own sets of rules, regulations and guidelines. Unlike newspapers, magazines, radio and TV news channels, which cater to a targeted audience and whose access is monetarily controlled, online media is free, open and globally accessible to a wider audience. So, it becomes vitally important that online media writer is versatile, creative and innovative in writing. The role of digital content writer does not remain confined to mere writing and editing but calls for other technical expertise, which you will be learning in this Unit. Moreover, with the arrival of multimedia and digital convergence which combines the features of all the existing media, the writer needs to be multitasking various roles while manning the news desk of the media house.

In this Unit, we shall discuss various aspects of the online media writing, its roles, and characteristics and also how to be an effective writer in the digital space. We shall also be discussing the syntax, language and sentence construction which are vital in writing news reports, analysis and feature stories. The Unit will lay special emphasis on SEO-friendly writing, which is very important to be seen and read by larger audience. Social networking sites such as Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, LinkedIn and Google Plus+ are major platforms to reach out to wider readers and the Unit will also offer practical advice to such specialised writing.

10.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After having gone through this Unit, you will be able to:

- understand the features and characteristics of online media writing;
- identify new practices in online media writing and implement it in your daily news reporting and writing;
- know how online media writing is technically driven and based on SEO algorithms;
- learn how to be an effective online media writer; and
- establish your credibility and credentials as an online media journalist and communicator.

10.2 FEATURE AND CHARACTERISTICS OF ONLINE WRITING

Before we delve into the features of online media writing, we must understand that online media is a technological leap from the earlier media. Every medium,

over the course of time, evolved its own writing style to suit that particular medium. Whether it is newspaper, magazines, radio or TV news channels, each has its own style, rules, regulations and guidelines of writing. But all have adhered to the basic tenets of news writing. The difference, however, is in the types of language, words, length of the news and its presentation.

The guiding principles of clarity, conciseness, continuity, correctness, commonness, credibility and completeness have remained common across the media. Also, each medium has its strengths and limitations. The writing style attempts to enhance its strengths and minimise its limitations. For example, print medium has the limitation of space and television has time/limitations. In both these cases, news writing has to be in a manner so as to fit the slot. Likewise, online media suffers from credibility deficit as it works under a fast-paced news environment with very little time for verification of the content and hence, the fear of ‘fake news’ looms large. The online media has to, therefore, take additional precautions while writing, checking, cross-checking and double-checking the facts before uploading it ‘live’ on the digital platform.

Like other media, the online medium is also a collection of breaking news, developing stories, features, articles, editorials, analytical articles, and so on. Each has its own style of writing depending on the subject and treatment given to it. Apart from these, online media also has multimedia content in the form of audio, video and ‘live’ streaming of events, which do not need much writing but has to have a headline and tags and meta tags to be picked up by search engines. In certain cases, sub-titles are also required if the media content is in a regional or foreign language. Another distinguishing feature of online media is its interactive nature, which needs a different kind of approach and writing style. It has to be such that it forces people to like, dislike, debate, comment or share it among friends and relatives.

You must have read that communication between the source and the receiver takes place when both of them have the same frame of reference. It means that news writer should know his/her readers’ choices, preferences in the need for information and news. In fact, the knowledge of audience, it is said, is more important than the subject itself for an effective communication. As digital news writers work on real time, the need for establishing creative connection is of utmost importance. As digital news writers address a diverse and heterogeneous set of people across the globe, the interest, attitude, experience of digital writers assumes special significance. To be a good writer on the digital platform, the writer has to be widely read as it helps the readers to identify with him or her. Former Chief Editorial Adviser of the New York Herald Tribune, Geoffrey Parsons, once said, “The richer the writer’s background, the larger his ability to stimulate thought about anything.”

Writing for the online media includes an interface between what a writer writes and the machine algorithms, which searches for it. As the content in the digital media are searchable, they are written in a format and style so as to be easily picked up by search engines. The headline needs to have important key words and the newness that it wants to convey. When the news item is published, it forms part of the Universal Resource Locator (URL), which is crawled by the search engine and indexed for further searches. Sometimes, the URL is inorganically created so as to include important key words for easy search and display. As news websites receive a large number of page views through search

engines, writing of URL is deliberately calibrated to maximise its reach. The density of keywords in the story page and giving sub-headlines, pointers, adding pictures and infographics further enhance the value of the page and form an important part of digital media writing.

As the attention span of readers on digital media is extremely low, headline should be written in a direct, effective and communicative manner without much jargons and superfluous content. The principle of brevity, clarity, creativity and continuity is retained in digital media as in any other media, leaving no chance for ambiguity. As more and more news content is accessed through smart phones these days, the content should be brief and to the point conveying the important points. The writer should not add his opinion or point of view and neither should they editorialise it.

10.2.1 Online Writing versus Print Media Writing

Online media writing, as we mentioned earlier, did not come from being taught. Rather, it evolved from the writings of the other media including print. Even now, a large portion of digital media content owes its existence to print media. As a consequence, it retains the print style of writing, apart from including digital details and formatting. Sometimes, headlines are changed so as to make it more search engine friendly and also to attract eyeballs. In some cases, paragraphs are broken into smaller ones, without affecting the continuity of the story for the sake of making it easy on the eyes. Inverted pyramid style of news writing is favoured both for the print and digital media as it includes the important points in the first paragraph of the news story.

A large number of news organisations have automated systems whereby the print media content is converted into digital web pages with minimal manual intervention. It is only recently, with the arrival of independent news websites, a separate and individual style of digital content writing is developing, albeit slowly. Many journalists from the print media, who have joined digital platforms have continued adhering to print media writing, thus providing little innovation to news narration on the new media platform. Another important factor influencing the writing of print and online media is that of periodicity. Periodicity of publication has significant impact on the style of news writing and its dissemination. A newspaper has a news production cycle of 24 hours till the next newspaper is printed. Digital media involves real time news production and hence, implicitly needs to convey the immediacy of news in its news writing.

While the print news stories stand solo, meaning it has no relevance or reference to earlier stories, news stories on digital platforms can have references to earlier stories through hyper-linking. The writing style on digital platform calls for more flexibility with innate understanding of the past coverage of the related news.

Hyper-link is provided to the already written text or at times separately embedded so as to bring it to the readers' notice. Another feature that provides flexibility to the digital platform is the ability to edit already published stories or adding or updating it. In the print media, a news which is once printed cannot be undone, but on the digital platform it can be edited and corrected. The online writers can make best use of such features.

There is a lot of similarity between the writing style of digital platform, radio and television. They address the audience directly and the style of writing and presentation is often conversational, colloquial and simple. Literary and technical jargons are avoided. One of the reasons for the similarity is that they all work in sync on digital media and form part of multimedia, which has come to occupy special significance on digital platform. In fact, online media is a combination of all these three. It is because of this feature that they prefer to follow the same script and style across the media. These days, radio and TV news channels are increasingly making use of the digital platform to reach out to audiences across the globe as it does not need broadcasting infrastructure. Although, they are independent of each other, they can be beautifully combined and optimised on the digital platform with a common style of writing and presentation.

As you know, radio is completely dependent on sound ‘bytes’, is a shared medium and gives liberty of creative imagination to its readers. As a result, it is often called “theatre of the mind”. It involves preparing a run down script, which has elements of speech, sound effects and music. Writing for radio must be simple, precise, direct and brief and should use familiar words to sustain the listeners’ interest. These features of radio script writing are quite akin to friendly news websites. Both convey a sense of immediacy being real time in their reach and in their presentation. Likewise, a TV scriptwriter transforms the visual content into spoken language, which is then broadcast for general consumption. Almost all TV news channels these days use YouTube, a digital platform, to reach out to global audience. The headline, description and content of videos are written in a way to make it easily searchable on search engines.

Check Your Progress: 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

- 1) What are the features of online media that calls for a different style of news writing?

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- 2) How is online media writing different from writing for print media?

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3) Why does online media writing sync well with Radio and TV scriptwriting?

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10.3 TYPES OF ONLINE MEDIA WRITING

Online media contains various genre of write-ups including news, articles, features, photo features, lifestyle, entertainment, sports, health and business stories. Unlike print medium, it has multimedia content and ‘live’ coverage of news, which sets it apart from other media. The writing style of each genre is specific to it and also they vary from one another. Although the basic parameters of language, vocabulary and grammar and syntax rules remain the same, expression and creativity differentiate one from the other. While writing for online media is a new genre’ by itself, there are new areas of interest evolving within it. And news related to entertainment, films (Bollywood, etc.), celebrities are much in demand and are getting huge page views. They are written in gossip style with pictures and quotations of the celebrities. Educational news, especially exam results is another area, which has been attracting a lot of attention and page views. The online writer has to keep monitoring such new developments and write brief news stories to satisfy the interest of readers.

Apart from writing news stories, another major responsibility of the online news desk involves editing stories filed by the reporters. Each reporter writes the story in his or her own style. The news desk has to see to it that it follows the inverted pyramid style and follows the style sheet of the organisation. At times, the news desk has to re-write a poorly written story to make a better sense out of it. All these tasks have to be performed simultaneously by the writer so as not to miss anything on the news front. As you will see, news is the most important aspect of online media and this thrives due to a competitive spirit amongst writers to be the first one to break a story.

10.3.1 Breaking News

‘Breaking news’ is news about which only initial information is available. It could be an accident, an earthquake, death of an eminent person or any event or happening. Such news is immediately flashed on digital media in the form of running ticker so as to attract immediate attention of the readers. This is the most important task of an online writer and he or she has to convey the news in the simplest language without any lapse of time. You must have seen tickers on TV channels, which carry a single or more than one line about an event. It is a moving text, one followed by the other. It informs as to what has happened and where, who are the people involved and the consequence of the event. The feature of ‘breaking news’ is common to digital media and TV channels but finds no place in print medium, as it has a 24-hour production cycle.

For the online news writer, the source of ‘breaking news’ could be reporters or news agencies, which flash such news on priority. Sometimes, the news websites

also take news from TV channels and attribute their source to it. This is done so as to avoid the copyright issues. As more and more details start pouring in, the news stories are taken off the ticker and a full-fledged story is written and published by the writer. Breaking news is written in active voice and in present continuous tense so as to describe the immediacy and continuity of the event.

10.3.2 Developing News Stories

Developing news stories fall between the categories of ‘breaking news’ and full-fledged stories. The example of landslide in Uttarakhand is a breaking story but as more and more news comes in, it is moved to the developing stories basket. Sometimes bullet points are added to it to show its developing nature. The above news could be added with information like “Rains hampers rescue operation,” “Road blocked between such and such city because of landslide,” “Uttarakhand Chief Minister visits hospital and meets those injured in landslide,” etc. Once all the details are obtained, the desk writes a complete news story. Sometimes, a backgrounder is added to the story to make it more detailed in nature. The positioning of developing stories is generally on the first frame of the website and on the top as it is the first lead of high news value.

As visuals and videos take longer time to produce time, they are the last to reach the news desk. The writer has to use some old file photo or any other creative content to convey the sense of loss and tragedy. If the media house has a reporter in the field, the writer sometimes calls him or her for more inputs and writes the story in detail. At times, inputs from TV news channels and news agencies are also incorporated in developing stories.

10.3.3 News Stories

For online media, news is at its core—the very heart and soul. It is the single most important thing and also one of its biggest assets. News is anything, which is recent, fresh and not known earlier. According to Joseph Pulitzer the main characteristic of news are that it is “Original, Distinctive, Romantic, Thrilling, Unique, Curious, Quaint, Humorous, Odd and Apt-to-be talked about.” It attracts attention because of its timeliness, proximity, prominence, consequence, human interest and mysteries.

A news article, ideally in the very first paragraph or introduction, should include the news by answering the Five W’s and One H. Who, When, Where, Why, What and How. About who the news is about, when the incident took place, where it took place, why it happened, what really happened and how it happened. News stories should ideally follow the inverted pyramid structure. It means the most important part of the story should be in the beginning, followed by other less important information in descending order. In the online media, name lead and quotation lead stories have assumed special significance as they attract maximum attention of the readers. In the name lead, it is the person who is important because of his or her public position like the Prime Minister, President or any celebrity. Quotation lead refers to stories where an important person has said something, which is important in the light of present situation.

While writing news stories, the principle of news value is adhered both in letter and spirit. The headline as well as intro should include it at the first place. News value is decided on the basis of impact, unusualness and prominence of the story.

The other attributes of a news story includes conflict, proximity and timeliness. While writing conflict stories, an element of drama is added in order to make it more readable. But in all given situations, a sense of balance and fairness is maintained and attribution is given for facts, figures and quotes. So, to sum up, the characteristic of good news writing includes accuracy, attribution, balance and fairness, brevity, clarity and readability. Irrespective of how important a story is, if it is not accurate and readable, it would not receive and retain the readers' attention.

10.3.4 Multimedia: Visual Story Telling

There is an old saying: "a picture is worth a thousand words." It is said that while words make features and photographs make visual features. They are called photo features because of dominance of visual elements. To be effective, photographs need to be conspicuously placed after their composition. Magazines and websites like Life and Time give special emphasis to photo features. While writing for photo features, the writer needs to give eye-catching headlines and captions to attract the readers' attention. Sometimes, the sequence of pictures is so arranged that it tells a story through its own unfolding style. Multimedia and photographs provide visual break from the clutter of words on the online media. They also enhances the beauty and meaning of a news or feature story.

Visual story telling is an art, which is learnt over a period of time and involves photo cropping, enlarging, reducing, sizing and retouching through special software programs like photoshop, etc. Grouping and clubbing are two important skills that are employed for visual effectiveness by the news desk writers. When two or more pictures are joined in such a way that they do not overlap with each other it is called 'grouping'. When they partially overlap during the process, it is called 'clubbing' of photographs.

Photo caption writing is an art and is used to add or elaborate the subject under consideration. If the story has a picture, then giving caption is not a difficult task but the writer must explain the context and the date of the photograph to explain its relevance to the story. At times, when there is no accompanying picture, a file photo is used to break the textual monotony of the story. In such cases, the writer must explain it in the caption that it is a file photo and does not relate directly to the story. In other incidences, when there is no story accompanying the photograph, the photo editor has to explain in detail the relevance of the picture.

Photo captions are given to arouse interest of the readers, which gives them an opportunity to react to the story. In principle, a caption should be brief, direct, and bright and should retain the relevance to the story. While uploading the pictures, the online writer has to give an Alt tag or attribute on image tag, so that it appears on the search engine. A brief description about the image helps the search engine to know what the image is about and when to display during search queries.

Audio, podcast and video are the distinctive features of online media and are its latest entrants. They are hugely popular amongst the youth, as they are easily understood. As these are one-way pre-recorded communication, it does not require much descriptive writing. Nonetheless, the online writer, while uploading these files, has to give the right kind of headlines (name and subject of the video) and what it contains to make it easy for the search engine. You must have noticed this

feature in YouTube while searching for relevant videos. The online writer has to intuitively understand what possible key words could be used to search for those particular audio or video files.

Check Your Progress: 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

Fill in the blanks:

- 1) is the distinctive feature of online media writing.
- 2) Breaking news about which much detail are awaited is called.....
- 3) is the software used by the photo team to crop, resize and enliven the images?
- 4) Apart from audio and video, is the latest entrant into online media.

10.4 THE SYNTAX OF ONLINE WRITING

Syntax is the arrangement of words and sentences to convey an idea and meaning. For online media, there are unwritten rules that a writer adheres to while writing news stories. Unlike literature, news is written for information and for people who may not have very high literacy level. Keeping the audience in mind, online writing demands simple and short sentence construction, which are easily comprehensible. The language used is matter of fact and direct instead of being long winding and beating around the bush. The purpose is to convey information and opinion directly, leaving no chance for ambiguity. Likewise, the words used should not have any double meaning or complicated sentence construction. Then number of words in each sentence should not exceed 16- 18 and a single idea needs to be conveyed in one sentence. Uses of complex sentences are best avoided while writing news stories, although they are often used in feature writing as part of creative liberty.

10.4.1 Writing Style-Language

As mentioned earlier, the language of news writing should be simple, clear and brief. As news is supposed to convey facts, important points should come first, followed by less important and then the least important. A reader needs to get the complete facts after reading the first paragraph. The rest are elaboration on what has been written earlier. It is a good practice to use colloquial or conversational language while sticking to laid-down framework of news writing. Use present progressive tense as much as possible to convey the immediacy of news. Keep the headline in active voice and be specific rather than general in conveying the information to your readers. You should avoid using definite and indefinite articles in the headline as it takes additional space and makes the URL long and winding and is of not much use for the search engines. The principle of clarity, conciseness, continuity correctness, commonness, credibility and completeness should be followed while attempting all genre of online writing. You should have a good functional vocabulary and knowing synonyms of words will help you avoid repeating the same word in a sentence.

10.4.2 Choice of Words and Phrases

Words are symbols and carriers of meaning and should be used carefully. Strong words and superlatives like the best, finest, and brightest should be avoided as they are relative and we have no means to ascertaining the claims. The words you use should be concrete, specific and should add to the weight and credibility of what you write. You should also try to use short words, as long words take additional space and reading them becomes a tongue twister. The use of words, which are commonly understood and are easy, should be favoured in the place of difficult words. It is often said “don’t throw your readers to the dictionary, otherwise your readers will throw you out of your job.”

Simplicity of words and language is the driving force of online media writing. Phrases, which are foreign to targeted audience, should be avoided. Instead of saying ‘it was raining cats and dogs’, it is better to say, ‘it was raining heavily’. Similarly, do not use the word ‘very’ too often in your writing to convey magnitude. Mark Twain once said that it is better to use word ‘damn’ instead of ‘very’ otherwise “your editor will delete it and the writing will be just as it should be.”

10.4.3 Sentence Construction

The rule of simplicity and clarity is applicable through all aspects of online media writing. Sentences form the basic bricks of the news edifice and hence, they should convey its salient features clearly. It should be brief and crisp and convey concrete meaning with one idea in each sentence. It is advisable to use short sentences, as they are easy to understand and takes less time to comprehend. It is advisable to avoid long convoluted sentences conveying multiple messages. If the sentences is long, it could be broken into smaller sentences, which at times may require re-writing. Ideally, a sentence should not contain more than 16-18 words. Punctuation marks should be used wherever necessary to convey the important idea. It is important that sentences flow effortlessly one after the other in a logical, and gradual manner. Abrupt break and moving from one idea to another without any connecting link should be avoided.

10.4.4 Structure and Paraphrasing

Reading a long text on a computer screen or a mobile phone can be a strain to the eye. That is one of the reasons why it is advisable to write short sentences and keep shorter paragraphs. It is better to break up the body text into smaller paragraphs each containing not more than seven or eight lines. Each paragraph should convey an idea which should be logically taken forward in the next paragraph. Sometimes, pictures and info graphics are used to break the monotony of a textually heavy page. Using bullet points and pointers helps in highlighting the important points in a news story. Although there is no fixed rule for paragraphing and structuring the body text, the online writer should keep in mind two important features of online behaviour. Firstly, the attention span of the readers is short and constantly flickering due to diversions on the web page like advertisement and scrolls. Secondly, the story should be able to sustain the interest of the reader lest he or she leaves the page and moves on to some other web activities.

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Briefly explain the syntax of online media writing.

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2) What do you think is the reason for keeping online media writing simple?

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3) In online media writing, which are the elements added to break the monotony of a text-heavy page?

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10.5 PLATFORM-BASED ONLINE MEDIA WRITING

Online media writing is expansive and is getting increasingly diversified in terms of content, devices and social media platforms. Each medium demands a unique treatment of its content. As the readers' profile vary from one platform to another, the writing needs to be calibrated to meet the demand of that particular medium. For example, people on social media like Facebook and Twitter prefer short and crisp write-ups, dominated by personal opinions and visuals. While Facebook encourages informal and personal content, Twitter is public, formal and follows a structured content. While writing for these mediums, one has to keep in mind the prevailing norms of the medium.

10.5.1 News Websites and Blogs

By now, you must be familiar with different kinds of content in news websites and their writing styles. Blogs are another form of writing which find place both on news websites and personal web pages. It is a personal and informal form of

writing. The subjects of blogs could vary widely from travelogue, technical writing on gadgets, health, entertainment or simple commentary on news and politics. Commercial establishments and private companies make use of blogs to explain their policy and decisions. In the online media, blogs are personal opinion on news, events and does not generally adhere to the editorial guidelines. The writing style too varies depending on bloggers' personal choice and preferences. Ideally, blogs should follow simple structure of introduction, middle and the conclusion.

10.5.2 Writing for Social Networking Sites

Social media writing has evolved into a specialised area of communication and is increasingly used by media organisations for 'breaking news' as well as sharing other kinds of content. It helps them reach out to a large and diverse audience across the globe. Generally, a social media post is a short teaser to attract the attention of readers along with the link of the story to the website. Social interactive sites like Facebook, Twitter, Instagram and LinkedIn have become popular places for exchanging news and information as well as personal opinion. A social media post should include the most interesting part of the story that has the ability to arouse sufficient interest in the readers to read complete stories. Some media organisations have entered into an agreement with some social media sites to provide all of their content to the readers. To ensure that you reach out to a wide audience, your writing has to be effective and should hit the bull's eye.

10.5.3 Interactive Writing

Unlike print and television, 'interactivity' is the most distinguishing feature of online media writing. An online writer can interact with the readers in real time and get feedback instantly. An online writer should continuously engage with the readers and should try to answer the query raised by readers, which are posted under the comment section. Some news websites have made it mandatory for readers to register themselves on the website before posting a comment, but a large number of them allow free posting of comments on news articles, but these are moderated. An online writer can invite opinion from its readers to know what they feel about a particular subject. Sometimes, opinion poll (a good example of interactive writing) is also used for the purpose.

10.6 SEO-BASED ONLINE MEDIA WRITING

What readership is to newspaper and TRP to television, page views are to websites. It tells how many people read your story and how long they stay on the page. It also decides the advertising revenue for the website. So, it is extremely vital both for revenue earning and the popularity of the news website. The golden rule is — 'no matter how good a story is if it is not read it has no meaning; So, the attempt of online news writer is to reach out to as many readers as possible. How can this be achieved? The following writing tips will be of much help in this regard:

10.6.1 Searchable URL-Based Headlines

Headlines are gateways to news. It is the door, which gives you a glimpse of the room and its contents. The thumb rule for headlines is — it should be attractive, interesting and eye-catching. If it is a news article, it should include important possible key words that the news wants to convey. For example, "18 students

dead in Surat coaching centre fire, many jumped off the building” conveys the complete meaning of the news. It shows the continuity and ongoing action of the event and also contains important key words. Anyone with a slightest idea of the event, keying in place name i.e. “Surat,” “Students Dead,” “Coaching Centre Fire” to search for the story on any search engine, will get it on the top as the news will be easily searchable and will be thrown on the top in the search engine results. The role of online news writer also includes the work of a Search Engine Optimisation (SEO). While giving headlines, you need to keep in mind how would you search for that particular story on the web. What are the key words that will help attract maximum attention? And while doing so please do not forget to convey the news in the headline.

10.6.2 Keywords and Tags

These are familiar words in online newsrooms as they find place in every news that is published online. Meta tags is a broader term which include title of the news, its keywords and a short description of the news. The Meta elements like HTML or XHTML provide structured meta data about the content of the page and are not visible to readers. Keywords are specific words, which are descriptive in nature and are separated from each other by a comma. Title tags contain keywords by which a story is indexed on search engines. Whenever a query is searched, the news items are displayed on the basis of relevant keywords. Description is a brief, two-liner statement on the content of the web page and could be equated with the intro of the story. Each search engine has its own parameters. Some give preference to keywords while others like Google priorities meta description and title tags. While writing for online, the writer should also provide these details before publishing a story on the web.

10.6.3 Concentration of Keywords

Higher the concentration of keywords in your story, including in the headline, description and main story, higher are its chances of getting picked up by search engines. Keywords have to be chosen very carefully and used judiciously. Too much of its use should be avoided lest it become repetitive and distorts the narration of the story. While writing a news story, the writer has to ensure that each paragraph contains important keywords. One should use pronoun wherever necessary but make sure that the name of the person, place or event has reference in the body text. News stories, which have novelties and newness, are given prominence over the same story carried by different websites. This is more so in the agency stories, which are carried by large number of websites. However, bear in mind that the above parameters of SEO keeps on changing based on the algorithms of the search engines from time to time.

Check Your Progress: 4

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Why SEO-based writing has become important for online news?

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- 2) Differentiate between the terms meta tags, key words and description of a news story?

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10.7 FACT-CHECKING WHILE WRITING

Checking facts, figures and images for authenticity is the foremost principle to be adhered to before any kind of journalistic writing is undertaken, it is even more important in the case of an online news article. Before you begin writing your piece, make sure that you have all the details with you and its veracity has been checked thoroughly from all available sources. Here are some guidelines, which will help you in doing this:

10.7.1 Visuals Fact-Check

Checking, counter-checking, cross-checking and double-checking of facts and figures are the hallmark of a well established credible digital content developer. There have been instances, especially on the social media, where photographs have been morphed and used in a different context, thereby distorting the very purpose of the news item. The online news writer also has to check whether the pictures used in the story is telling the whole truth or part of it. Only relevant pictures should be used in the news story. Morphed or altered images used for the sake of sarcasm or parody should be avoided. James Russell Wiggins, former editor of the Washington Post once said that, “The camera can be a notorious, compulsive, unashamed and mischievous liar.” So, the writer needs to check the validity and relevance of the picture of a particular story that he or she is writing.

10.7.2 Fake News Check

In this age of digital and social media, dissemination of ‘fake news’ has become rampant and finds easy way into mainstream media and most commonly on digital platform. Fake news is disinformation and is carried out with a malafide intention and ulterior motive. While writing for online media, the onus of authenticity of news lies with the writer. He or she should check the claim from reliable sources and all facts and figures should be checked meticulously. The images used in the story should be credited to the source to avoid both copyright as well as disinformation allegations. Claims made by a person or an authority should be attributed and should be corroborated from other sources. Fake news has become a major concern and even reputed media houses have been caught napping in this regard. To ensure credibility, authenticity and correctness of news, a fake news check is a must for all online writings

10.7.3 Credibility, Credentials and Communication

Online media writing is a serious profession and at par with any other journalistic work. Credibility of news is what makes or mars the reputation of a news website.

Online writers have to ensure that it is not compromised at any point while disseminating the news. There are laid out rules and guidelines for checking the authenticity of news which should be followed vigorously. Trust between the receiver and the sender of the message is the bedrock on which communication takes place. This trust is not earned overnight but built over years and decades by media houses. And the first gatekeeper of the trust is the online news writer.

10.8 LET US SUM UP

After having gone through this Unit, you must have understood the difference between online media writing from that of print and electronic media. Online media, however, has retained the salient features of print media like rules of grammar, sentence construction and syntax. We have also learnt that online news writers have to be equipped with many other technical skills, which form the part of the job profile. As your stories are read on computer, laptop, palmtop and mobile screens, it has to meet the demands of that particular technology. Also, online media writing is SEO-based and should have the ability to appear on search engines and be seen by large section of heterogeneous readers.

10.9 KEYWORDS

- 1) **Hyperlink:** through text or images, an element of a webpage is linked with another page or document or any online content. Hyperlinked text is called hypertext, usually hypertext looks blue in colour with underline. By clicking or tapping this link, the intended online content will open.
- 2) **SEO:** with the help of Search Engine Optimisation you can make your website more visible and top ranking in any web search results by introducing relevant keywords in your web pages. SEO usually brings more users due to higher visibility.
- 3) **URL:** universal Resource Locator, it is a technical term for a popularly used word website address. URL points to a folder which is existing in a computer networks. Normally domain names are registered for any website which is then linked to folder that contains all pages related to that particular website.

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10.11 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress: 1

- 1) The real time dissemination of news, its interactive features and Search Engine Optimisation (SEO) of content demands a different style of news writing for online media. Unlike print media, the news has to be short, conveying newness of the content in the headlines. The sentences have to be short so that they are easy on the eyes. Language needs to be simple so that it could be understood by heterogeneous masses. The guiding principles of clarity, conciseness, continuity, correctness, commonness, credibility and completeness needs to be adhered to, both in letter and spirit.
- 2) Both print and online media follow inverted pyramid style of news writing. It means the most important piece of information should come first, followed by the next important point in the descending order. The difference lies in real time dissemination of news, which is the strength of online media. Print media on the other hand, has news production cycle of 24 hours. Also, the accessibility of online media is global whereas print media is constrained by geographical circulation. Interactivity is another distinctive feature of online media. Keeping these features in mind, the style of news writing for online should be immediate, in present progressive tense and should use active voice to convey the immediacy of the event.
- 3) Online media as well as radio and TV news convey information in real time. It means when news is being read out on TV and Radio, it could be seen and heard at the same time by the audience. In case of online media, however, there is a small time lag as online publishing takes time. But then, its reach to a wider global audience compensates for the time loss.

Check Your Progress: 2

- 1) SEO (Search-ability)
- 2) Developing stories/news
- 3) Photoshop
- 4) Podcast

Check Your Progress: 3

- 1) Syntax means choice of words and arrangement of sentences to convey an idea. For online, there are unwritten rules that a writer adheres to news

writing. For example, the words used in the story should not have double meaning nor should it unnecessarily complicate the meaning of the sentence. The number of words in each sentence should not exceed 16-18 and it should convey a single idea in each sentence.

- 2) As the attention span of readers online is limited and flickering, it calls for attention-grabbing headlines and introduction for sustaining interest of the readers at the same time. Besides, long sentences create optical problems and often strain the eyes. Also, the fact that news stories could be searched online and are meant for heterogeneous audience means that the style should be simple, clear and effective.
- 3) Text-heavy page means a web page, which contains text only. It also means that sentences are long and paragraphs uneven. As text-heavy pages are eye straining, it is advisable to use photographs, infographics, blurbs and other such visuals as visual breaks and to make the page light and easy to read. The body text, if possible, should be broken into smaller paragraphs, without affecting the continuity of the narration.

Check Your Progress: 4

- 1) The very reason for writing news is to be seen and read by the readers. To enable it to reach out to a large audience, online news should incorporate the latest SEO practice so that it gets prominently displayed on the search engine. In this way, it will also help serve the audience better by providing relevant news and information. Critics of online media often allege that news is written based on SEO and for getting eyeballs instead of educating the masses. There seems to be some truth in this allegation too. But it should be realized that news and information are 'needs' and what kind of news people read is their prerogatives. Also, with the coming of online media, news is seen more as a product to be sold in the digital market than a missionary zeal.
- 2) Meta tags is a broader term, which includes title of the news, its keywords and a short description of the news. The Meta elements like HTML or XHTML provide structured meta data about the content of the page and are not visible to the readers. Keywords are specific words, which are descriptive in nature and are separated from each other with a comma. Title tags contain keywords by which a story is indexed on search engine and whenever a query is put, the news item is displayed on the basis of relevant keywords. Description is a brief, two-liner statement on the content of the web page and could be equated with the intro of the story.

UNIT 11 ONLINE NEWSROOM SETUP

Structure

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- 11.1 Learning Outcomes
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- 11.11 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

11.0 INTRODUCTION

Newsroom is at the very heart and soul of any media organisation as it is here that news and ideas are formed, shaped and presented to the masses for general consumption. And the online newsroom is no exception as it buzzes with activities, discussions and real-time dissemination of news and information to the public at large. Like print and electronic media, in online media too, the mass-produced messages are transmitted to a large, anonymous and heterogeneous group of

people. However, there are some distinctive features, which differentiate online newsroom from others in the *genre*. Firstly, there are lesser number of people involved in the news production process in the online as compared to the print newsroom. Secondly, it reaches a much wider audience because of its World Wide Web presence and cutting across national boundaries. Thirdly, the cost of news production is much less compared to traditional media because of fewer human resources involved, the less expensive raw materials and infrastructure. In addition, we also see that the online newsroom has become an exciting place for the younger generation and all those who are well versed with digital technology.

In this Unit, we shall discuss the role, features and functions of online newsroom setup of a media organisation. It will help you to differentiate it from other traditional media newsrooms. This Unit will also help you to learn about new technologies which online newsroom setups are utilising to reach out to larger audience.

11.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After working through this Unit, you will be able to:

- explain how the online newsroom of a media organisation works;
- identify the role of various departments in online newsroom setup;
- illustrate the role and importance of Content Management System;
- use the recent technologies to access news and information; and
- apply social media for news dissemination and to connect to larger audience

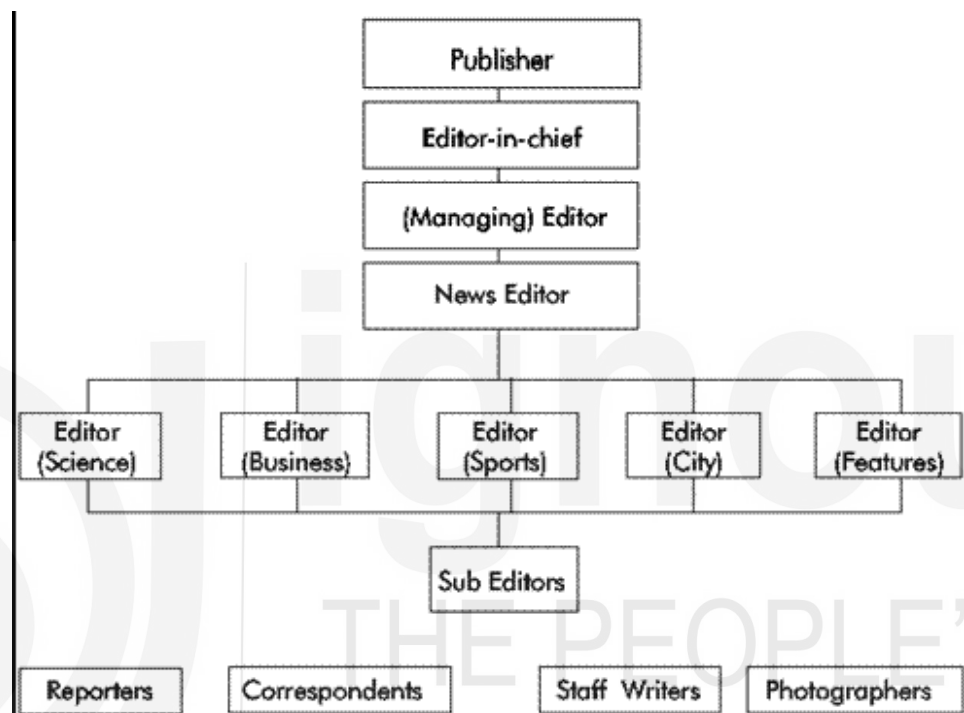
11.2 ONLINE NEWSROOM: FEATURES AND CHARACTERISTICS

The structure of the online newsroom largely depends on the size of an organisation and its media product. As the volume of work is more in bigger organisations, it needs more people to man the news website. Bigger organisations provide news updates 24X7 and usually run in three shifts, each headed by a News Editor. The timings are generally from 8 am to 4 pm, 4 pm to 12 midnight and 12 midnight to 8 am. The late night shift is often called the graveyard shift because it is night in the host country to which the website caters. Its main responsibility is to scan the national and overseas news. The news updates during the graveyard shift is generally less and far in between.

It is during the graveyard shift that dailies send their newspapers to press for printing. A soft copy of the newspaper, which is generally designed in QuarkXPress, is sent to the online newsroom. The graveyard shift ensures that the latest edition of the newspaper is uploaded and made live (published) on the website. The timing of a newspaper going live varies from organisation to organisation, depending on their policies. Some organisations publish their latest edition much before the newspaper comes out of the printing press. They assume that print and online audience are different and have different reading habits.

An online newsroom shift is headed a News Editor, who also happens to be a Shift-In Charge. About 3-5 Sub-Editors/Content Writers, with responsibility to

ensure error free and free quick updates, assist the News Editor. In case there is a major event of disaster or terror attack or a plane crash, they promptly flash the news on a ticker, even as the detailed information starts to come in. A ticker is a band of running script on the top of a website, which provides breaking news or news of utmost importance and about which much details have not been received. Once the online newsroom receives some basic information about an event, it develops it into a story and waits for more inputs to filter in. Such stories are called developing stories. Fresh inputs are either updated in the earlier story itself or a new story is filed giving links to the earlier one, which serves as a backgrounder. This is called hyperlink as it enhances the comprehensibility of a news story.



A typical newsroom setup in a newspaper (Source: UNAIDS)

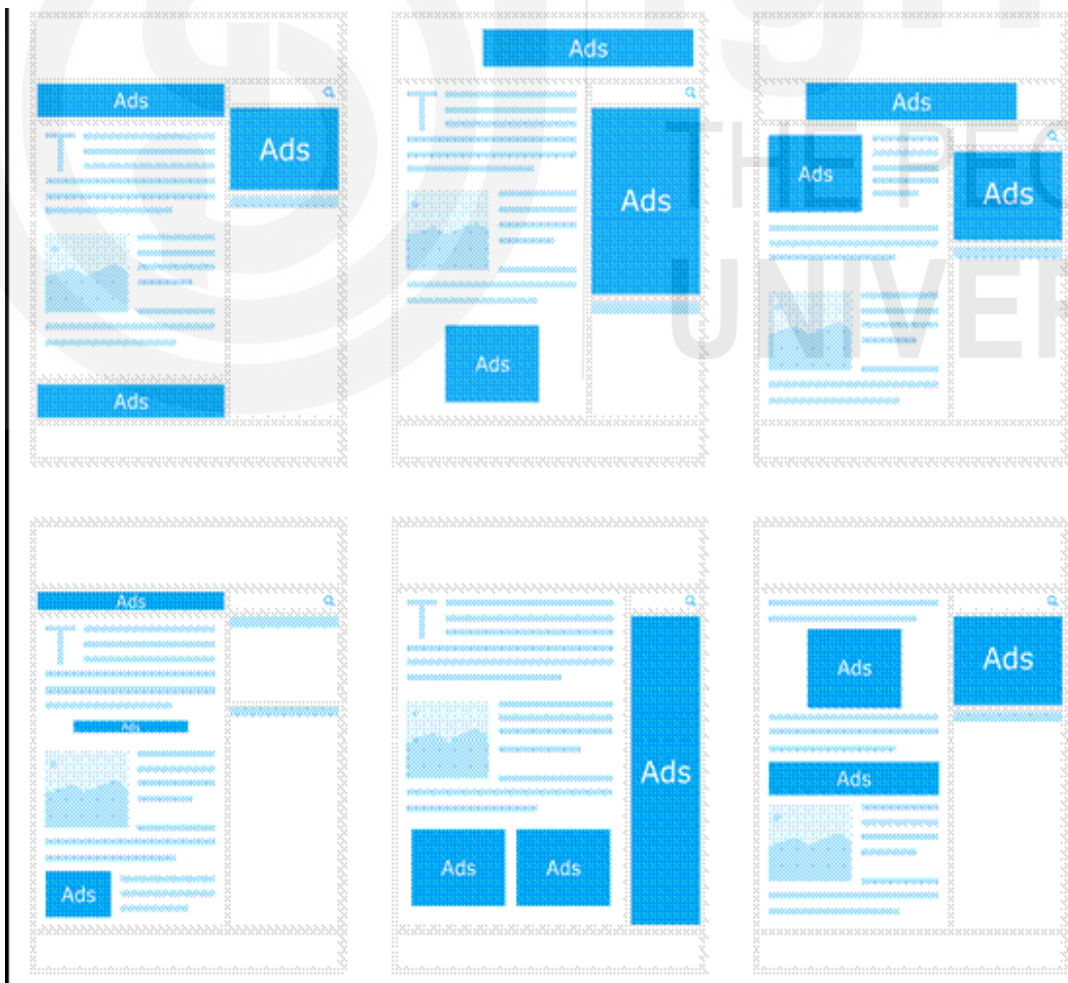
These days, most websites, make use of timeline for quick understanding of the facts and figures. It includes detail of the story as it happened and the time of its occurrence. Sometimes, to give it a visual appeal, it also includes infographics and pictures of the event in the story.

Apart from the editorial team, which includes a news editor and sub-editors, a technical person also assists the online newsroom operation in rectifying technical error that might creep in during the operation. Although most websites are self-sustaining and such technical eventualities are rare yet; it is always safe to have a technical person on a standby. As the workflow is greater in big organisations and the editorial team has less time to focus on visuals, a designer is often assigned to help the editorial team with photographs, graphics, and animation depending on the need of the hour.

We are now fairly aware of how an online newsroom works and is structured. Let us now focus on individual genre of media operations and see how they work.

Every medium has its own strengths and limitations. The role of online newsroom also is to enhance and amplify its unique strength and tone down its limiting factors. As you may know, newspapers played an important role and were major source of information till late twentieth century. But newspapers have physical constraints of circulation especially to remote and foreign countries. The online media fulfils this gap of reaching to wider geographical areas with the help of newer technologies. Another limitation faced by newspapers is lack of print space. Here again, the online media comes to the newspapers' rescue, as it does not have any space constraint. The stories, which do not get space in the print edition, are put up on their websites. Local news is of immense help to those travelling or living in foreign countries. It gives them a sense of belonging and connectivity. The online media connects them to the news of their native land. To give readers a feel of newspaper, most websites have e-Papers on their websites, which are a facsimile of physical newspaper.

In recent years, there has been a major shift with the majority of news magazines turning their online operations into news website with 24X7 updates like the India Today and Outlook magazines. The new changes were necessitated because of stiff competition for advertising revenue and to catch the readers' eyeballs. As a result, there is no major difference these days among the various news websites, except that they belong to different flagship media organisations.



Layout templates for a newspaper; design software helps to focus on creativity

The news source for a magazine's online newsroom is generally news agencies, which provide non-stop news feeds. There are few stories done by the reporting staff for the website. There is, however, some difference in the technology employed.

Unlike a newspaper, which is generally designed in QuarkXPress, pages of a magazine are designed in In-Design and the online team is provided with a PDF version of the magazine for its upload onto the website.

11.2.2 Online Newsroom Setup of Electronic Media

The online medium has made the best use of audio and video files by incorporating them in their operations. The newsroom setup of TV news channels like NDTV, CNN-News 18, India Today, Times Now, Republic TV, AajTak, ABP News and radio websites is not much different from that of newspapers, except that it requires specific skill sets for processing audio and video files.

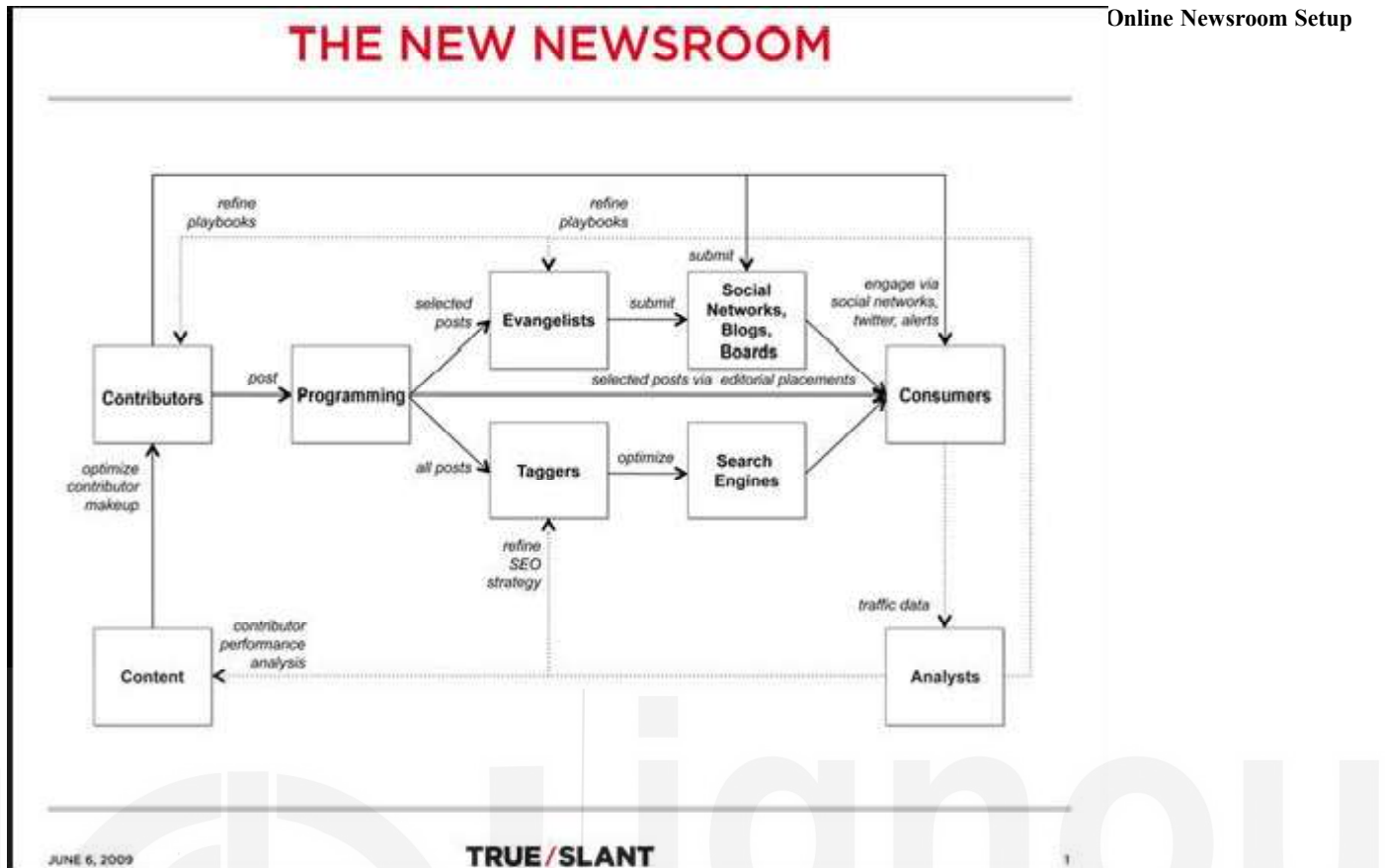
The audio and video clips from radio and television are optimised to match the internet speed so as to provide seamless listening and viewing of their content. Some TV news channels provide live streaming directly from the event venue. As a result, a person can see the same programme both on television as well as on their website in real time.

TV news channels and radio however, have limitations of coverage. It is not possible for them to convert all news inputs into audio and visual bytes as it leads to loss of precious time in news broadcasting. To overcome this handicap, the online newsroom ensures that such news items are displayed in textual format on its website before audio and video inputs are ready for upload. The role of TV online newsroom is very much demanding as it calls for multiple skills and multi-tasking to ensure prompt and quick news updates.

11.2.3 Stand-Alone Online Newsroom Setup

The internet has opened up a new window of opportunities for the media industry. Its strength lies in its ability to communicate with the masses in a very cost-effective manner. Earlier, it was not possible for a common man to start a newspaper or a TV news channel as it involved huge costs and massive infrastructure. But internet has abolished these barriers. Now, anyone with an enterprising idea or the capability can start a news website with a moderate investment.

You must have heard about bloggers. These are people who write blogs. The blogs are a kind of mini news websites and do not need investment. It is nonetheless possible to start a news website with moderate investment. Anyone with an enterprising idea or capability can start a news website. Most media houses have their own news websites and enjoy the credibility of their flagship product. In recent years, many news website have come up, which neither represents a media house nor are affiliated to any media products like newspaper or TV news channels. First Post, Huffington Post (India), Cobra Post, Scroll, Catch News, The Print, The Wire and data journalism website, India Spend are some of the examples of independent news websites.



The typical digital platform based newsroom setup (Source: www.forbes.com)

The news source for stand-alone websites is generally its own staff or contributors and columnists who specialise in politics, economy, sports, social issues, entertainment, etc. The newsroom setup of such organisations is similar to other media organisations and is headed by the Editor. They have their own reporters and contributors who bring news stories from the field and send it to the editor for publishing it on the websites. These reporters sometimes also double-up as photographers and camera person as well as record the audio and video. The manpower of these news websites varies from 4-5 to 20-25 or even more, depending on the scale of its operation. They either have their own technical team or it is outsourced to a third party. However, over a period, these websites have established their own independent identity and have started enjoying some amount of credibility in the news sphere.

Check Your Progress: 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) How does the online newsroom function?

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- 2) List three distinctive features of online newsroom and one of its advantages.

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- 3) What does stand-alone website mean?

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11.3 ONLINE NEWSROOM: TEAM WORK

The manpower strength required for a newsroom is decided keeping in mind the scale of its functions. Of this, 80 per cent are generally the editorial staff. The editorial team works in three shifts to provide the latest news on a 24X7 basis. And often during the outbreak of a major incident, more people are pooled in to meet the contingency of increased news updates. The working of an online newsroom is a collective team effort as it involves reporting, editing and publishing hundreds of stories every day. Besides, there is also a need for visuals in the form of photographs, videos, infographics and multimedia etc to make the story attractive and eyeball grabbing.

Once a story goes 'live' on a website, it becomes necessary that it reaches a wider group of readers and appears on search engines where people search for the latest updates. It is here that the role of Search Engine Optimisation (SEO) and Social Media Optimisation (SMO) comes in to play an important role. They ensure that the news stories are searchable and visible on search engines.

These days, a large number of people are connected with media organisations via social media for the latest news updates and news analysis. The role of social media team is to make its stories available on social networking sites like Facebook, Twitter, Google+, Reddit, Pinterest, LinkedIn, Tumblr, Baidu, WhatsApp, WordPress, StumbleUpon, etc. Often, readers subscribe to newsletters of various websites, which are sent directly to the subscriber's email. There are also options of customised newsletters, whereby a reader can opt for his/ her areas of interest to receive newsletters related to it.

Let us now see how each of the online newsroom teams work to make the newsroom a smooth running operation.

11.3.1 Editorial Team/Content Writers

An important role of an online editorial team is to ensure quick and fast news update as it is all about speed, accuracy and credibility of the news that matters

to be placed on the online platform. This is because the news gets flashed immediately and reaches readers in real time. This inherent capability of the online medium gives it a rare advantage. Before news gets splashed on the television or in a daily newspaper, it has already reached millions of people through the internet.



IT team is highly skilled and takes charge of developing special packages

Operating in shifts, the editorial team, however, have their eyes glued to the TV, news agencies and other websites to know what is happening everywhere. The news scanning process continues along with news updates, writing and publishing stories online. If any member of an editorial team notices some important news, he/she immediately alerts the news editor, who depending on the merit of the story, decides its placement on the website.

An online editorial meeting chaired by the editor is a routine exercise to discuss important news development of the day. The edit meet also plans and discusses news events that need to be covered in the coming days. The edit team remains in constant touch with the technology team, design team and photo team for its day-to-day requirements.

11.3.2 Technology Team

The technology team is also an integral part of the newsroom as it facilitates the process of carrying the news to the worldwide audience. The strength of the technology team depends on the magnitude of operation and varies between 4-5 staff headed by a Chief Technological Officer (CTO).

A major responsibility of the technology team is to look after the Content Management System (CMS) via which news stories, photographs, video and other multimedia content are uploaded on the web servers before reaching the audience. Web servers are collection of network computers, which make the web pages available to multiple users across the globe. The role of technology team is highly skilled and falls under the Information Technology Unit of the organisation.

The technology team has also to ensure that the download time of the website is fast, so that there is no delay in news reaching the users. A common technical error on the website is HTTP 404 Not Found Error. It means that the users are not able to access a web page, which they are looking for. This happens generally when a page is removed from the website or is moved from its particular location. At the user end, the error occurs when a user types a wrong Uniform Resource

Locator (URL) on the web browser. The technology team tries to minimise such errors as it affects the credibility of the website. The 'tech' team, as it is generally referred to in newsroom, also helps the editorial team in developing special packages for news coverage during important events like polling, election results, accidents, terror attacks and so on. The 'tech' team tries to improve the interactivity between the users and the newsroom by developing special interactive interfaces. Comments, feedback and poll questions are some examples of the interactive features of a news website.

11.3.3 Design Team

The design team is responsible for the look and feel of the website and plays an important role in making it visually attractive. It decides the placement of the headline, introduction, body text (the main story) and the pictures on a web page. The design team also decides on the sizes of the photographs, which appear along with the story at various places on the website. The Homepage (it is like the front page of a newspaper) of the website, the section pages like India, World, Politics, Business, Sports, Photo Gallery and Blogs, etc., are all designed by the designing team to categorise news stories into various sections. This is however, a one-time affair and does not change very frequently. On a day-to-day basis, however, the design team assists the newsroom in developing special features, infographics and the picture presentations for the website.

11.3.4 Photo and Video Team

In a majority of the online newsrooms, the photo and video teams are clubbed together. However, in the TV news channels where the flow of videos tends to be greater, a separate video team often looks after the video uploads for its online operations. As the videos are heavy files and take more time to download, they are processed in MP4, 3GP or VLC format for quick streaming on desktops and mobile devices. The agencies, which supply videos to various organisations, send it in a customised format compatible with the requirement of the organisation. The photo team, on the other hand, selects the relevant pictures for news stories, crops it depending on the required size of the story and sends it to editorial team for enhancing the visual appeal of the story.

The photo teams usually work on Photoshop software and try to optimise the pictures for websites and other devices, depending on its format. They make the file size much smaller by reducing its weight and thus ensuring a quick download. Some of the websites have now started using larger pictures for greater visual appeal. Photographs are generally sourced from news agencies, which provide round-the-clock news pictures. Sometimes, when there are no real visuals for a story, a representative image is used to break the textual monotony of the web page.

11.3.5 SEO and SMO Team

The roles of Search Engine Optimisation (SEO) and Social Media Optimisation (SMO) teams are to ensure that the stories filed by the editorial team appear on the search engine. A large number of people go to the search engine to find the latest update on a story. To maximise easy visibility of a story on search engine, important key words are included in the headline, which are in turn picked up by the search engines. While filing a story in CMS, the editorial team also puts in

important key words, meta tags and a short description of the story. It helps the search engine in locating a particular story, meta tags, on the other hand, define the content of a web page. An important role of the SEO and SMO teams is to post stories on social networking sites and directories.

11.3.6 Social Media Team

The role and growth of social media in news dissemination has been phenomenal in recent times. In fact, a sizeable chunk of readership to various news websites comes from social media, especially Twitter, Facebook and many more. As a result, big online media organisations have established a separate division, which looks after the social media operations. The moment a story goes 'live' on the website, it is immediately put on the social media.

These days, social media networking sites like Facebook, Twitter, YouTube, Reditt, WhatsApp, LinkedIn have become popular places for breaking news and for political, business and sports personalities to declare their opinion on a particular issue.



Big media organization can do without a strong presence in the social media

Sometimes, the opinion of these leaders itself becomes a news and is carried by newspapers and websites as a news story. Also popular media organisations tend to have huge number of followers of their social media pages. They in turn, share and re-tweet news stories, which further reaches more and more people like a chain reaction. These days no big media or business organisation can do without a strong presence in the social media where big data has come to play a major role.

Check Your Progress: 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

Fill in the blanks:

- a) A common technical error, which a tech team come across is error.
- b) Videos arefiles and take more time in streaming.

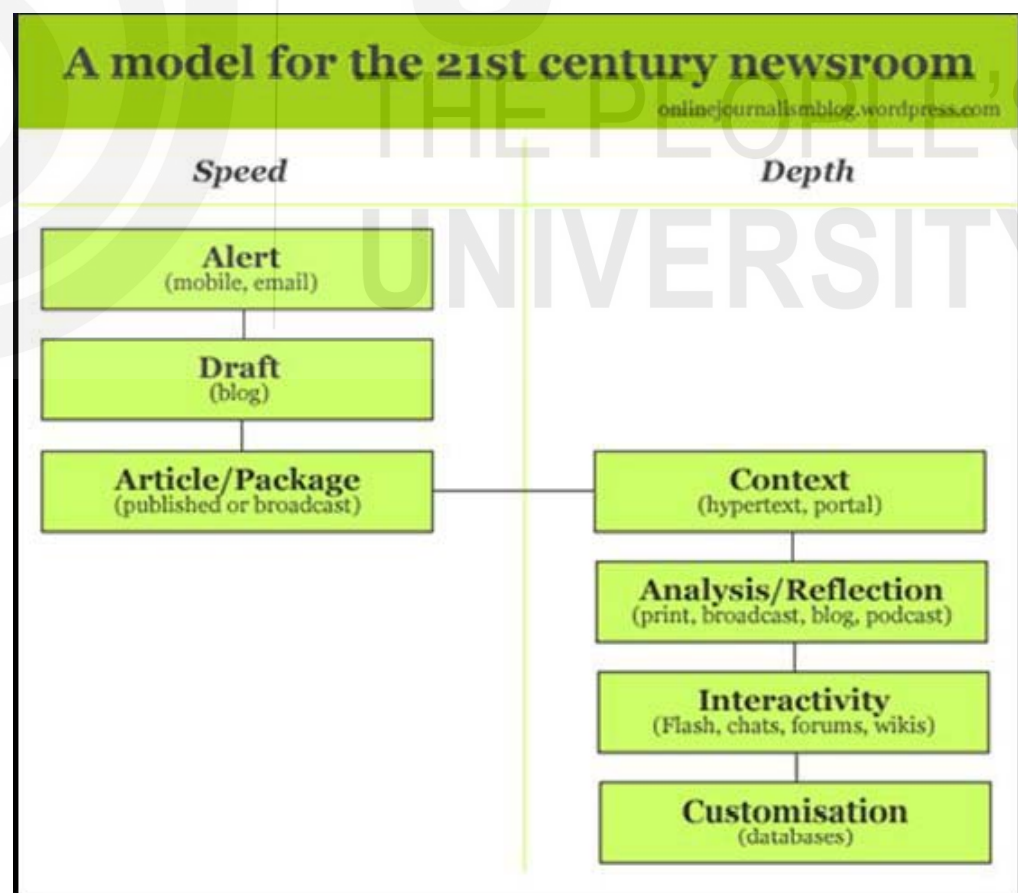
- c) A large number of people go to..... to find the latest update on a story.
- d)are the two most popular social media sites.

11.4 ONLINE NEWS WORK FLOW

By now, we are quite familiar with the role of a various departmental teams who work in 'sync' to give shape to every-day news operations. The organisational structure of an online newsroom is much similar to print and electronic media except for the inclusion of technologically skilled workforce. Here, we will briefly talk about the role of the editorial team as they are the 'pivot' of newsroom activity and play a crucial role in defining the character of an online newsroom.

11.4.1 Role of the Editor

The editor of an online news operation is the final gatekeeper of all the content that goes on the website, including the textual and the multimedia formats. The editor guides, instructs and steers the day-to-day operations and oversees the team members who reports to him/her. While the other departments of the newsroom like technology, design, SEO, SMO and social media have their own heads, they all work in tandem with the editor. The editor, apart from the editorial content, is expected to have a thorough understanding of technology, so as to carry forward and implement new changes on the website.



Unlike other media, new ideas and innovative concepts are introduced in the online newsroom more frequently. The editor generally initiates the new concepts after doing a feasibility test and an impact analysis. The editor, being the head of

the newsroom, chairs the daily editorial meeting. An important role of the editor is to plan the coverage of forthcoming events including elections, festivals and incident-based special projects.

11.4.2 Role of Copy Editor

The role of a sub-editor or copy editor is very critical in an online newsroom operation as he/she is the first gatekeeper of the news. If an error is introduced at this stage, at times it remains undetected and gets published online. Therefore, a sub-editor has to be very careful about the grammatical and factual errors and has to continuously crosscheck the facts. A sub-editor is the eyes and ears of the newsroom and has to remain alert and calm while dealing with news. Although news coming from news agency are generally error-free, due diligence is required before publishing it online.

In the newspapers and TV news channels, where once news is published and broadcast, no correction can be carried out thereafter. The online media, however, provides the rare advantage and flexibility whereby errors could be corrected at any stage of news production, even after the news is published. However, such unpleasant situation is best avoided as it creates embarrassment for the organisation. A sub-editor has also to visualise the news item before it gets published and has to add relevant multimedia content for its visual appeal.

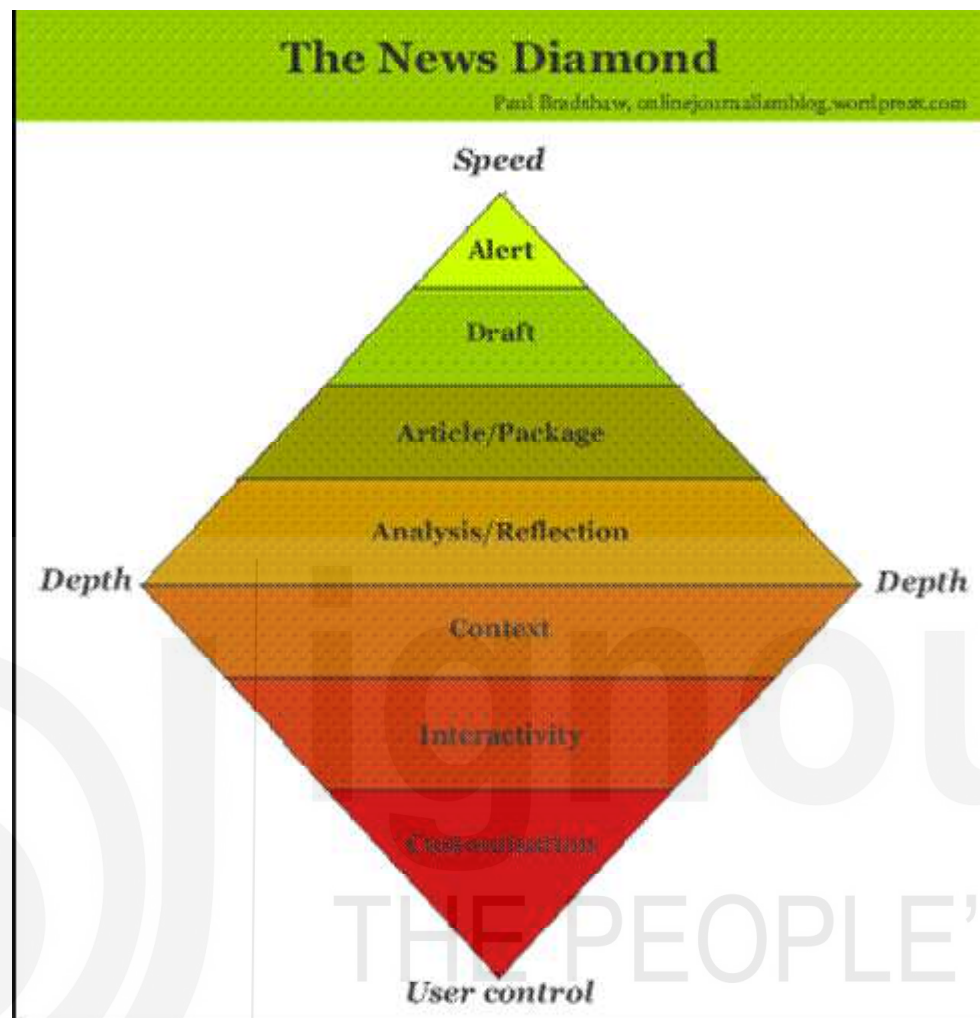
A news story with a good headline immediately catches a reader's attention. So, a sub-editor has to continuously work on the headline to make it catchy and attention grabbing. Breaking the story first is the governing mantra in online publishing as websites compete with each other for a premium slot in the breaking news segment. A sub-editor is also expected to have sound technological knowledge as s/he has to work on advanced tools of online publishing including the CMS.

11.4.3 Pattern of News Cycle

As we discussed earlier, the flow of news in online newsroom is much greater than in any other traditional media. Hundreds of news stories compete with each other for a place on the homepage but only dozens of them get featured on the first screen of the website. Unlike the print media, there is no space constraint in a news website and hence, a large number of important news items are featured in various sections of the website. As there are large numbers of stories which are published on a given date and the shelf life of a news story is very short based on its importance and relevance only few are picked up. Breaking news and developing stories enjoy higher degree of visibility than an analytical opinion piece on the homepage.

Readers are generally more interested in knowing about what is happening at that very moment on various trending stories and the online newsroom seeks to cater to such curiosities. The online media provides the unique capability of retrieving an old article from its archive and linking it to the recent one. The process of linking one article with the other is called hyper linking. The archival stories provide historical perspective to a recent news development and are of rare value. In recent times, it is noted that some news websites are trying to make their archival stories a paid content, whereby a user has to pay some amount online to access them.

The processing of a news story begins at its very source when a reporter of a media organisation or news agency files the story. Thereafter, it comes to the online newsroom where it is checked, edited and published online.



A responsive website is the one which appears the same on all devices.

A news story gets its place on the homepage depending on its relevance. The news editor generally decides the placement of a news story and instructs the team of sub-editors accordingly. A developing or breaking story is given a prominent place on the homepage and is continuously updated as more information filters in through various sources. Sometimes, a sub-editor is also expected to write a story from viewing TV news channels and in such he/she attributes the source to that particular TV news channel.

11.4.4 Interactive: Opinion Poll, Responses and Comments

Interactivity is one of the major characteristics and a chief differentiator of the online media. It means two-way communication between the sender and receiver of the message. The traditional media like newspapers also have interactivity feature in the form of letter to editor and telephone feedback, but the process of feedback is painfully slow, time-consuming and delayed. In the online media, on the other hand, the degree of interactivity is much higher, easier and in real time. While interactivity has been a marginal feature in the traditional communication media, it is the main characteristic of the new online media. Opinion polls and comments are examples of interactivity features in online media. While it takes 24 hours for a comment to appear on a newspaper, the process is instant on

online media. Other examples of interactivity is emailing an article, sharing it on social media, and liking an article on Facebook and tweeting and re-tweeting it on Twitter. Likewise, when you cast your vote in an opinion poll, it gets instantly displayed at the other end. In fact, the popularity of online media largely depends on its ability to provide higher degree of interactivity between the two communicating individuals, groups and organizations.

Check Your Progress: 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Describe the role of an online editor.

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2) What is news cycle in an online news operation?

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3) What are interactive features of a news website?

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11.5 ONLINE CONTENT MANAGEMENT SYSTEM (CMS): THE BACK-END

The CMS is a central online publishing tool. It is the backend on which sub-editors work to publish a story on online. While the homepage of a website is the front-end, the CMS is the back-end and is not visible to readers. Access to CMS is password protected and is generally given to editorial team only. The rights to work on the CMS could be regulated by giving limited access to members, depending on the responsibility assigned to him/her. Also, access to the back-end is not in public domain to safeguard it from hacking and misuse.

The CMS can be compared to QuarkXPress on which a newspaper is designed before printing. Most of the news websites have their own CMS which are developed by a technical team to meet the specific need of that organisation. CMS is generally built by software companies and is either outsourced or developed in-house by the technical team. When you read a story on a web page, you must have noticed the placement of headline, introduction, blurb, photographs, caption and texts, etc. These placements are decided by the CMS which follows a pre-set command.

11.5.1 Feature and Characteristics

The CMS, as a central tool of news publishing, has all the features that you see on a web page. There are slots for headline, byline, introduction, blurb, body text, photos and multimedia data, which are fed-in in specific fields to appear on the web page. The text fonts and the types are executed in the CMS. Photographs are sometime inserted in the body text and hyperlinked to archival stories. For the stories to appear on search engine meta tags, description and key words are put along with the story. This helps the search engine pick and display a story a user is searching for. To check that there are no errors on the web page, the CMS also provides the option of previewing a page before it gets published on the public domain.

11.5.2 Strength and Flexibility

The strength of the CMS lies in its versatility and its openness for modification. New features can be added to it at any point of time and it is often an ongoing process. Being a dynamic platform it facilitates the process of online publishing through easy, convenient and user-friendly steps. There is yet another advantage of the online media. A sub editor who has been given access to CMS can publish a story from anywhere, at any time and from any device. News stories and breaking stories can be flashed on the website even while a sub-editor or reporter is on the move. Majority of popular news websites, however, have a central newsroom to which news stories are sent for editing and publishing. A very significant advantage of the CMS is its ability for error-correction, which could be carried out even after a news story is published. (Detailed descriptions on news website production through CMS is given in Unit 15.)

Check Your Progress: 4

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What is the role of CMS in online newsroom?

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- 2) While filing an online story, what are the different fields that need to be fed-in into the CMS?

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11.6 RECENT TRENDS

Digital media is a technology-driven evolving platform. New innovations, ideas and concepts are added to it more frequently than in any other traditional media. The introduction of mobile telephony has made access to news a universal phenomenon. In India, there are more than a billion mobile phone users with over 159 million having access to Internet on their handsets. According to a year report by internet and Mobile Association of India (IAMAI), the number of internet mobile users is expected to double in the coming years. These days more and more people are using mobile phones to access news and multimedia content. For a better user experience, most media organisations are making their websites responsive. A responsive website is the one which appears the same on all devices including the desktop, tablet and mobile handset irrespective of their operating system. The mobile phone has assumed such a central stage in digital communication that organisations have now adopted 'mobile-first' concept. It means a website is designed and developed keeping in mind the mobile handset users instead of the earlier priority which was given to the desktop.



A responsive website is the one which appears the same on all devices

11.6.1 Mobile News App

News apps are the recent phenomenon in digital communication. An App is an abbreviation for Application, a software programme developed for specific purpose and usage. They are developed for small, wireless devices, especially mobile and smart phones to meet a particular requirement. An app can be downloaded on a mobile device using a browser. It gets stored on the device and the moment, a news item is updated on the website or on the app itself, it gets reflected at the user end. It is a short cut to reaching to the media organisation's website. With the result, a user does not have to go to through the website repeatedly for fresh news updates. Instead, s/he has to simply open the App and read the latest news. An app is an easy and convenient way of reaching out to a media organisation for news updates.

11.6.2 Mobile SMS News

When there were no apps or mobile internet connections, Short Message Service (SMS) was used extensively for news and information dissemination. Important and breaking news were flashed and sent to users via SMS. However, SMS service had the limitation of number of text characters. It meant that the news has to be very short and should have specified number of words only. News, SMS service is generally provided by mobile service provider as a value added service. The source for SMS news is not the mobile service provider but media organisations with which the service provider enters into a formal agreement for providing the SMS news. In recent times, the popularity of news SMS has declined, especially with the coming up of app and mobile internet. But there are still sizeable numbers of users who are using this service for breaking news updates.

11.7 READERSHIPS, REACH-OUT AND RESPONSE MEASUREMENT

As we all know, the popularity of a newspaper is determined by its readership and for a TV news channel, by its Television Rating Point (TRP). Likewise, the popularity of a website is measured by the number of page views it receives from its users. When a user clicks at a link or headline, s/he sends a message for loading a single web page or HTML file. This results into a page having been viewed by the user. The higher the page views of a website, the higher is its popularity and consequently the revenue from the online advertising. It determines the value of advertising revenue and is used as a marketing tool.

There are various analytical tools to measure the page views but the most popular one is Google Analytics. In fact, page views are of so much importance that all members of online news room, from the editor to sub-editor, have their eyes glued to analytics to know which news story is being read most and by how many people.

11.7.1 Page Views Analytics

While it is possible to find out the readership of a newspaper, it is quite difficult to measure how many people have read a particular news story in the newspaper. The online media, on the other hand, has a unique advantage of knowing how many people are reading a story on a real time basis. It also tells us the

demographic details of the users. It is of immense help to the newsroom in determining the newsworthiness of a story and in planning news strategy. The analytics also provide details of archival story and measures the page views for days, weeks, months or even years. The analytics tells us the source of the traffic (number of users) as well, whether people are accessing the website directly or are coming to it from the search engine or social media sites. One can drill down further into analytics to draw statistics of the reader's reading behaviour and time spent on the site.

11.7.2 Cost Per Thousand (CPM)

Cost Per Thousand (CPM) is a common metrics to measure the online advertising rate and is derived by dividing the number of page views by thousand. It means, the lesser this value, the greater is the benefits to advertisers. Pay-per-click (PPC) and Cost Per Click (CPC) are other terminologies which have assumed greater importance because of their effectiveness in ensuring that the users have clicked a particular web page advertised on a website.

11.7.3 Response Measurement

While analytics provide a measurable metric for determining the popularity of a news story, there are other parametric like interactive, which are of immense help to online newsroom. Comments on a story are an interactive feature, which tells the newsroom about the readers' engagement to a particular story. Comments also provide a rare insight into the readers' opinion on a particular issue and the biases of the author, if any. An interesting story invariably helps in creating a healthy discussion among the readers. Sometimes, the newsroom has to intervene and moderate the discussion and cull out abusive comments and derogatory remarks. In the social media, one can measure the response to a story on the basis of like, share, tweets and re-tweets. These are some of the advantages that online media enjoys.

11.8 LET US SUM UP

In this Unit we discussed how online newsroom functions in real situations. We looked into its salient features and explored how it differs from the newsroom of traditional media like newspaper and TV news channel. We discussed how online newsroom, apart from editorial, is a skill-based and technology-driven medium and calls for speed, accuracy and the ability to work under workflow pressure.

While discussing about the online newsroom, we tried to find out the role played by various departments like the editorial team, design team, technology team, SEO and SMO and the social media team. In addition, we also learnt that publishing and managing online operations is teamwork and that different tasks call for different skill-sets. We also tried to find out as to how news coverage during important events like election, festival and terror attacks are planned, managed and executed.

While elaborating on the role of the editorial team, we tried to explore the online media as more response-driven than the traditional media. We came to know that the news cycle in the online media moves much faster and has shorter shelf-life. We briefly outlined the role of CMS as an online publishing tool and learnt about the flexibility and adaptability that the online newsroom has.

To sum up, it can be said that the online newsroom combines all forms of publishing activities, from editorial to technical and that it is quick to adopt new technological innovations and the parameters of its popularity is measurable. It also offers immense possibility for scientific and demographic analysis of its readership and the editorial content.

11.9 KEYWORDS

Interactivity: It is an interactive feature on a website where the user interacts with the editorial content. It is generally in the form of opinion poll, comments, multimedia and social media.

CMS: The Content Management System (CMS) is a central online publishing tool. It is the back-end of the website and is not visible to readers. It is always password protected for security.

Cost Per: It is a common metrics to measure the online advertising **Thousand (CPM):** rate and is derived by dividing the number of page views by thousand, cost per thousand.

Multimedia : The multimedia on a news website is composed of text, photographs, video, infographics and other visual aspects on a web page.

News Cycle : New Cycle refers to the flow of stories from reporters/ news agencies to sub-editor, news editor and its final publication on the website. The shelf life of a news story is very short

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11.11 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress: 1

- 1) The working of online newsroom functions.
 - Provide news updates 24X7.
 - Works in three shifts, 8 am to 4 pm, 4 pm to 12 midnight and 12 midnight to 8 am.
 - Each online newsroom shift is headed by a News Editor.
- 2) Three distinctive features of online newsroom
 - There are less number of people involved in the news production process;
 - The cost of news production in online medium is much less;
 - It has low-cost infrastructure;
 - One of its biggest advantage: reaches larger audience because of its World Wide Web presence
- 3) Stand-alone website means
 - Stand-alone websites are those, which does not have any flagship media product like newspaper, magazine or TV news channel
 - The website's identity is independent of any associated media house.

Check Your Progress: 2

- HTTP 404 Not Found Error
- Heavy
- Search engines
- Facebook, Twitter

Check Your Progress: 3

- 1) Role of online editor
 - a) The online editor is the final gatekeeper of all the content, including text and multimedia, that is published on the site
 - b) The editor guides, instructs and steers the day-to-day operation of the online team
 - c) The editor, being the head of the newsroom, chairs the daily editorial meeting
 - d) The editor plans the coverage of important events like elections and guides the team on special projects.
- 2) Interactive features of a news website
 - a) Opinion Poll
 - b) Comments
 - c) Multimedia
 - d) Social media

Check Your Progress: 4

- 1) The CMS is a central online publishing tool. It is the back-end of the website and not visible to readers and is password protected.
- 2) The different elements that need to be fed in the CMS include the headline, introduction, Blurb, photographs, captions, multimedia files, story text, description, key words, meta tags, etc.

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UNIT 12 CONTENT PRODUCTION: ONLINE MEDIA

Structure

- 12.0 Introduction
- 12.1 Learning Outcomes
- 12.2 Content Creation for News Websites
 - 12.2.1 Core Writing Skills
- 12.3 Content Creation for Blog
 - 12.3.1 Personal Blogging
 - 12.3.2 Professional Blogging
 - 12.3.3 Creating Blog Content
- 12.4 Content Creation for Mobile Communication
 - 12.4.1 Content via SMS
 - 12.4.2 IVR (Interactive Voice Response)
- 12.5 Basics of Video Production for Web News
 - 12.5.1 Know the Medium
 - 12.5.2 Take the Time to Work
 - 12.5.3 Pay Attention to Production Values
- 12.6 Audio for Web
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 - 12.8.5 Follow the Web Convention
 - 12.8.6 Be the Consistent
 - 12.8.7 Provide the Reader Support and Feedback
- 12.9 Let Us Sum Up
- 12.10 Keywords
- 12.11 References and Further Readings
- 12.12 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

12.0 INTRODUCTION

In this Unit, you will learn the process of content creation for a variety of new media platforms. New media includes all writing of audio-visual production intended for the internet, mobile devices and evolving technological devices such as tablets or any other platform. We are going to discuss about the skills required for content creation for news websites, blog content and content for mobile communication. We also cover the basics of video production for web

news audio. Then we will take an overview of the basics of flash journalism production techniques.

12.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading through this Unit, you will be able to:

- learn the skills required for content creation for news websites, blogs and mobile communication;
- gather basic knowledge of video production for web news as well as audio for web;
- understand the concept of flash journalism and its production techniques; and
- know the concept of navigation and site design for content production in news websites.

12.2 CONTENT CREATION FOR NEWS WEBSITES

Creating content for the dynamic nature of new media is indeed a challenging exercise. Hence, it is not very difficult to find examples of both poorly executed online contents as well as a few highly creative and innovative ways of presenting online contents. Content creation for news has mainly three challenges. First, news websites have to deal with news which is just a click away and stories tend to get old very quickly. In this scenario, catering to the users by keeping the content updated is a challenge. The second challenge is that news websites have variety of options in presenting a story e.g. with the help of texts, images, videos and animation. Content creators have to pick the right media options as per the nature of the content. And third challenge is to how to make websites more interactive to attract more users to the website.

Keeping the above mentioned challenges in mind, the journalist needs to counter with effective contents. To achieve this objective, the journalist needs to take care of certain requirements.

12.2.1 Core Writing Skills

Generally people are of the opinion that online media consists of lesser text and also the popular opinion is that online platforms are for showcasing the content in visual form. But if these people try and assess their own online activity they will find that a majority of their online works are related to text. Millions of emails and comments are available online in text form. It is the text which makes the web itself work, through the linking of pages with HTML (Hyper Text Markup Language). Text is an important media element for online media. If you are a good writer, people will read all the way through your news story to the end whether it is on web or newspaper. While writing for the web, the online news writers need to generally fulfil the following criteria:

Be Compact:

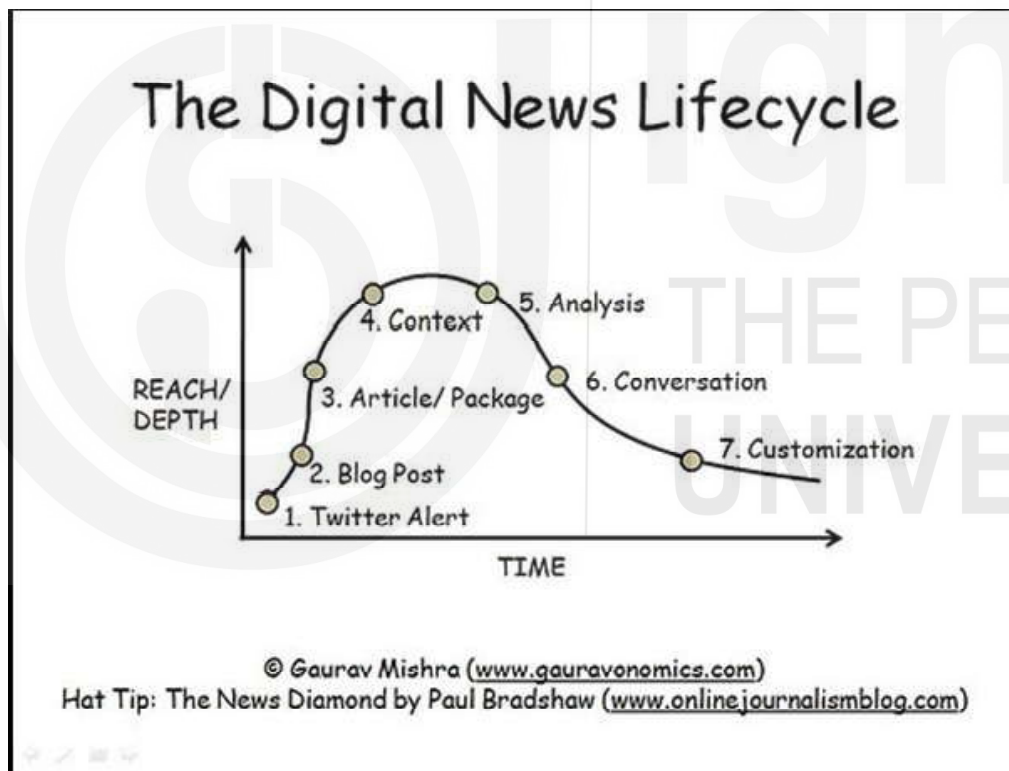
In the web, content compactness is required. Many researches have found that online users read 30 per cent less than print. They do not tend to scroll down to

the end to read full story. Hence, online writers need to be compact while drafting online content.

Bring scanability to the Story

The tendency of online users is to just browse through the web page. They keep jumping from one page to another. In this scenario, if the online news writer want to attract the attention of the users to the page, they have to make their pages more scanable. To increase scanability online writers can use many available facilities.

- a) Give bulleted information: Online journalists should give the important information in bullet points. It improves scanability of the web page. While browsing through the web page, users will stop at the bulleted information.
- b) Highlight important keywords: Some important keywords should be highlighted so that the users can get through the story fast. It also needs to be stressed here that browsing eyes cannot catch more than three-four highlighted words at a time. Hence, highlight only those words which have a greater influence in the story. Highlighting more words serves no purpose but can irritate the users.



- c) Do not hesitate to use images: Images speak louder than words. If you have images available to add with the story do not hesitate in doing so. Images not only improve the story presentation but also validate and compliment text.
- d) Use tables and brief profiles: Journalists should try to use tables and profiles of personalities within the news story, wherever possible. It makes content more scanable and the readers get gain extra information in an easy manner. For example if you are covering a cricket match it would be always useful to use tables containing match summary. Similarly, if you are covering a personality try to provide a brief profile so that users can relate to that personality.

Give related information

Online journalists have the upper hand when compared to journalists working in other media in terms of providing background information. Here journalists can provide related information by providing hyperlinks of related stories. It increases the credibility of the story and users can get full information at one place. But journalists should try not to provide too many hyperlinks. Use your judgments and be careful in choosing hyperlinks.

Tags and Keywords

These are essential part of the web content. Without tags and keywords you would not be able to reach larger number of net users. Keywords improve the Search Engine Optimisation (SEO) of your content. It means it enhances the possibility of your content to feature in search results. Therefore, there are better chances of the search engines picking up the keywords of your story. In CMS (Content Management System) the journalists have an option to add additional keywords to the story. It is a journalistic skill to give right kind of keywords which would improve the search-ability of the story. Online journalists should try to use phrases instead of words as keywords.

Tags improve functional interactivity of site. You must have seen some words at the end of a web story. These words are tags. When you click those words it brings you on a web page carrying all the related stories to the tags. It improves functional interactivity and credibility of the website. So tagging is also an important part of web content. Online journalists should be well versed with this feature and should try to give limited and important tags only.

Check Your Progress: 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What has to be done to increase scanability of the online story?

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2) What is the use of Tags and Keywords in the content of news website?

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12.3 CONTENT CREATION FOR BLOG

Blog is a discussion or informational site published on the World Wide Web and consisting of discrete entries. A blog can be managed by an individual or a group of people or an institution. Blogs are broadly divided into two categories:

12.3.1 Personal Blogging

Personal blogging is blogger centric. It means that you can write whatever you want and whenever you want. In personal blogging, bloggers have freedom to choose topics. It is seen that in these types of blogs, the blogger tends to write his/her personal opinion on issues which maybe at times highly biased. Generally bloggers choose topics which have surfaced in the mainstream media and usually give their own opinion on the topic. Following the code of conduct and professional ethics are individual choices in personal blogging.

12.3.2 Professional Blogging

A professional blog is reader centric. Here as a blog writer you do not have the liberty to write according to your interest. You have to keep your reader in mind while deciding the topic. That usually means an ultra-focused topic at a regular schedule. It does not mean that everyone should forgo writing a personal blog for a professional one. Personal blogs are definitely the fun parts of blogosphere. But if your goal is to make money from blogging, you must make sure you are always serving your readers not just sharing your personal opinions.

12.3.3 Creating Blog Content

While successful bloggers have to keep their heads alert to many different aspects of the medium but at the core of it all is the ability to write a compelling and engaging content. There are no specific rules or styles recommended for doing this. Generally, it varies from one blogger to another blogger as each blogger will have his/her own style of writing. However, there are some basic principles of writing a good blog content that might be worth keeping in mind.

Take Time to Create: Many a times it happens that an idea comes into your mind which you try to write about and finish it desperately. You sit in-front of your computer and write as fast as you can and hit publish button with hope that thousands of visitors will like your post, but you may find that the reality is quite different. This raises the question as to what went wrong? If you had a fresh idea then why was it not liked as you had hoped it would be?

The answer may be that you did not give yourself enough time to reflect upon your idea and frame it into a good content. Creating a blog post is more of a thought process that involves crafting the fresh idea into words or content that can take readers into a journey of their imagination. Hence, it is important to pause and focus on given key points instead of rushing through a post.

- a) **Choosing a topic:** Take some time in choosing and finalising a topic. If you choose a topic after putting some extra effort in looking at it from your readers point of view, it is bound to attract your readers rather than abruptly or randomly choosing a topic.

- b) **Crafting the title of the post:** The title of your post is also important in order to attract a greater attention from your readers. It is your title which is seen first in search engines and through RSS feed. Give some extra time in settling for the post's title.
- c) **Adding depth:** Always try to add some depth in your blog post. Do not be superficial in your approach, before hitting publish button think about how you can add greater depth to your post. In-depth posts are always of greater use to your readers. Your motive should be to give some extra information to your readers.
- d) **Make your points count:** Make your post matter. It is not only about writing. If you write something, make your point clear and those points should be of some worth to the readers. If you are not able to prove your point, the readers may not turn to your blog post.
- e) **Polishing of posts:** Some minor mistakes made in your blog can be a barrier for engagement with readers. Try to fix even the smallest of the errors before finally uploading the content. Fixing errors will take the content to the next level.
- f) **Conversation with readers:** Always try to facilitate a conversation with your readers and other fellow bloggers. Be open to discuss things with your readers. It will make your blog more interactive and will also help you to update and add some more value to your write- up.

Make Your Blog Post Scannable: Online users often have a tendency to just browse through the contents. It is the responsibility of the online writer to organise the content in such a manner so as to provide them maximum information in a short time. This is possible by making the content scannable. You can bring scanability to your content using various options given below.

As discussed earlier, 1. Try to give important points in bullet form. 2. Give bold, italic and underlined information. 3. Headings and subheadings in bold letters catch more eye balls. 4. If you have relevant pictures which are complimentary to the text always try to attach them in your post. 5. Always try to use small paragraphs in your write-ups. Ideally, in online, two lines paragraphs should be followed. Writers should also try to focus on one idea per paragraph so as to not puzzle the readers.

Check Your Progress: 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What is the difference between personal blogging and professional blogging?

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12.4 CONTENT CREATION FOR MOBILE COMMUNICATION

Mobile content is any type of electronic media which can be viewed on mobile phones, like ringtones, graphics, games, movies and navigation. As the mobile phone use has grown exponentially since mid-1990s the significance of the device has increased for the media industry.

Content via Messages



12.4.1 Content via SMS

Short Message Service (SMS) continues to remain as the main technology for communication used to send messages to mobile consumers. Media houses are using this technology to provide various kinds of contents to mobile users such as news, alerts and non-news contents. As these contents can be sent only as messages, the content developers have to keep certain limitations in mind. Firstly, the content must be written in a way that it must not exceed one message limit that is 160 characters (character includes spaces). Secondly, as the content has to be written within 160 characters, the content must carry valuable information in it. Thirdly, the sentences should be grammatically correct. Sentences with short form of words are not allowed.

- a) **Mobile News:** Media houses are using this facility to provide news to mobile consumers. It is not a direct kind of communication from media houses to mobile users though. Mobile service providers are also involved in it. Mobile service providers outsource news related content creation to the media houses. Media houses sell news content for mobile phones directly to the service provider. Mobile news is divided into broad categories e.g. National, International, Business, Sports etc. News for all these categories is sent several times in a day as per the demand of the service provider company. These messages are sent in various languages. English and Hindi mobile news are more in demand now-a-days.
- b) **Imagery as alerts:** Media houses provide various alerts to mobile users like romance alerts, health alerts, and grooming alerts and so on. It is found that mobile users particularly the youth segment subscribe to such alerts.
- c) **Non-news content:** Non news content like jokes, trivia on special occasions are also on demand. You must have received messages seeking subscription to various message alerts including alerts on special occasions like Durga Puja and Deepawali. On these occasions the service providers send alerts carrying religious and historical importance of the occasion.

12.4.2 IVR (Interactive voice Response)

IVR is a technology that allows a computer to interact with humans through the use of voice. IVR systems can respond with pre-recorded or dynamically recorded audio to further assist users to how to proceed. This technology is widely used in mobile communication by media organisations. The whole work for this is divided into two parts. One is writing for IVR and the second is recording.

Writing for IVR is different from writing for other mediums like print and TV. You can relate to an extent the IVR news writing with script writing for radio. Sentences for IVR news should be short and compact. Words used in IVR must be mike friendly because all the words are not captured by the mike.

The IVR news is generally a group of seven-eight important stories which are recorded dynamically by media houses and sent directly to the mobile service provider. The service provider sells this product to its users on subscription basis.

Check Your Progress: 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Define the term IVR.

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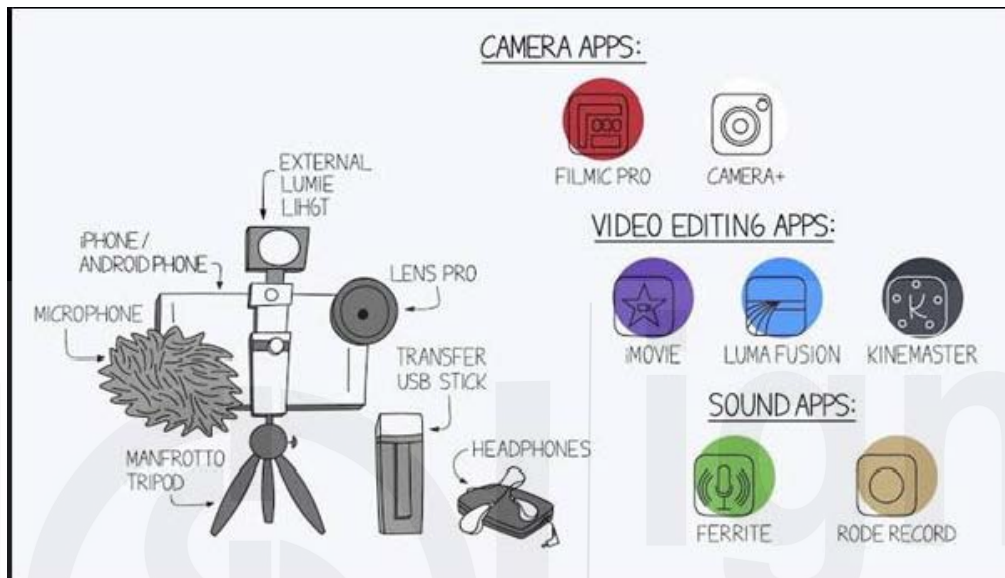
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12.5 BASICS OF VIDEO PRODUCTION FOR WEB NEWS

Video on web are the emerging trend in news website. A well made piece of video can help you deliver your message more effectively, educate readers, stimulate discussion and get your brand going far beyond your own domain. Providing a video link to a story improves the reliability of the story and brings multi-linearity to the story. Apart from technical requirement, journalists need to understand some important skills for creating a good video.



12.5.1 Know the Medium

Web video contains the qualities of all other media. First, it has audio, second, it has visuals and third, as it is related to a web story it also has written text. Journalists must understand that all these different media should appear to the end user as one unit conveying a single message. For this the journalist needs to ensure three qualities in the web packages.

- i) **Correlation between text and audio:** Correlation between the text and audio is necessary for web packages. Take the example of an actor coming to a town and being surrounded by a large number of fans. If the text is stating this, then the audio related to that package must be supportive of the text.
- ii) **Correlation between audio and video:** Audio and video should also be complementary to each other. Take the same above given example wherein an actor is surrounded by large number of fans and the audio is carrying a deafening sound of clapping then video should also show a huge gathering.
- iii) **Correlation between text and video:** Correlation between the text and video is also necessary for a good web package. If the text is showing that the leader got angry on the stage then the video should also show the same footage.

These correlations are very important as the web medium is an amalgamation of all different media forms. So the video for a web story is different from video for TV, as on the website video is a part of package carrying other mediums such as text, audio and pictures also.

12.5.2 Take the Time to Write

Unfortunately, people just rush to upload a video on website and pay little time for writing. If you see video on websites you will find that the script is not well written and the tone of the voiceover is very low and not clear. If users are not satisfied then what is the relevance of adding an extra medium to the web story. Generally, the target length for most web video is five minutes or less. You should be well aware of this fact as you write and prepare for production. Understand that within five minutes there needs to be a beginning, middle and end to the story being conveyed. Hence, you will have to make a narrative structure of the video package which should not look incomplete.

Remember to make it as engaging as possible. There are various things pinging in the mind of users like emails, tweets, galleries, etc. To make it engaging you need to understand the watching habits of users. Again the watching habit of an individual user and a group may be different. It is also important to note that most people watch web video alone and sharing is done not with people present but through social media and email. So on website you have to also concentrate on lone watching habits of individuals. Take the example of comedy. Laughter is contagious, and viewers tend to have more laughing groups. But a lone viewer's laugh out moments are going to be shorter and fewer. Keeping this fact in mind web videos should be edited in such a way so as not to leave gaping holes after jokes for the laughter you are expecting. If you do it you will end up with a vacuum.

12.5.3 Pay Attention to Production Values

To produce a good video you need to pay attention to some important production values.

- Get the lighting right to ensure that quality of web video is good.
- Make sure that the voiceovers are audible. Sometimes the voiceover for the video is recorded without paying attention to the ambience which results in echo. So make sure that users can hear the dialogues clearly.
- Ensure high quality audio-video effects by using editing software. Make sure that these effects look simple as users are not coming to your web video to watch matrix.
- (Final Cut Pro (FCP) and Adobe Premiere Pro are widely in use in the media industry for editing purposes. Go to the tutorials of these editing software and learn basic skills of editing.)

12.6 AUDIO FOR WEB

The internet has transformed the nature of message delivery as well as the consumption habits of information seekers. These days, the internet has a variety of options to deliver the messages including text, images, video and audio. Audio can be used as an effective medium to introduce interactivity in the website. It is learned that users tend to revisit websites that are entertaining and offer a variety of information in a short time. It is pertinent to note that many of the effective news websites like Voice of America (VOA), BBC and CNN are using audio in addition to text, images and video.

There are various ways to add audio to the website:

Introduce Your Website

A recorded welcome message may create an emotional attachment and bring in the much needed human touch to the virtual experience. Certain websites offer an introductory audio message while visiting its home pages. This is supposed to increase its interactivity level.

Enhance the Written Content

Audio can be used to improve readability of a particular page. To do so, an audio clip can be used to convey the summary of the content. Even one or two lines will be enough. But make sure that the message is conveyed in an enticing form and it encourages readers to read on.

Guide Navigation from Page to Page

Navigation is an important part of any website. At times, visitors to a website get agitated when they are not able to find a particular page on a website easily. For this, if an audio file is attached to guide users to navigate from page to page it may enhance reach of the website.

Record Podcast

A podcast is a media file (usually audio or video) that is available for download via syndication. By subscribing to the podcast feed, each new instalment of the podcast is directly delivered to your computer to be played back at your convenience. Many news websites use this facility to add expert views as an audio podcast to the story. Suppose there is any important political development and you want to add some expert views to your story including that of a political editor then there is no point in adding video clip to the story. People are interested in listening to the comment of the person and that can be provided through audio podcast.

Holding Audio Discussion Board

As already mentioned, new media is a field of multi-tasking. It includes a variety of platforms to promote interactivity. One of the medium is audio and this can be used in a variety of ways. One of the audio platforms is to hold audio discussion board. It is little bit different from textual discussion board which is widely in use in various websites, where users interact on a certain topic with the media persons or an expert. In audio discussion board, the users will be able to interact through the audio medium.

Check Your Progress: 4

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What is a podcast?

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12.7 FLASH JOURNALISM PRODUCTION TECHNIQUES

Flash is a multimedia platform used to add animation, video and interactivity to web pages. Flash is frequently used for advertisement and games. Nowadays it is widely used for enriching its content by news websites also. Flash manipulates graphics to provide animation of text, drawings and still images. It supports bidirectional streaming of audio and video. It can capture user input via camera, mouse and keyboard. It has object oriented language called Action Script.

12.7.1 Uses of Flash in Journalism

Flash addresses two key needs in online journalism. Firstly, it integrates multiple media content and secondly, it makes it possible to reach the widest possible audience. Journalists generally use flash to illustrate and narrate news stories.

- i) **Maps and Data:** Illustration by maps is used when a journalist wants to show the effect or impact of certain incident across a wide area. Take the example of Tsunami which is seen to be frequently devastating many parts of the world. To show the site of devastation, worldwide maps will be more appropriate. Data are also integrated to the map to give complete picture of the incident.
- ii) **Timelines:** Sometimes users are more keen to know the sequences of an event. To provide this, a journalist can best illustrate it by using timeline in flash. Take the example of serial bomb blast in a city. To show the locations and the time of the blasts in the map, journalists integrate timeline in flash to project the whole sequence of events.
- iii) **Events:** Sometimes journalists do not have images or footage of a particular event. In such cases also the journalists prefer to use flash to cover those events. It usually happens if the event has taken place instantly in a distant area. Take the example of a train accident which has taken place in the middle of night. Certainly there can be no journalists present there to cover that incident. To overcome this, the journalist may use flash to illustrate the whole story

12.7.2 Flash Techniques

Flash enables the story to be told with audio, photos, text and graphics along with their interactive features. This makes flash a powerful journalism tool. The users can access and enjoy the content in the manner they want to. This can be done by using various techniques available in Action Script 3.0. Now flash is also having 3D tools which can create small and basic 3D animations.

Check Your Progress: 5

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What is Flash technique in online journalism?

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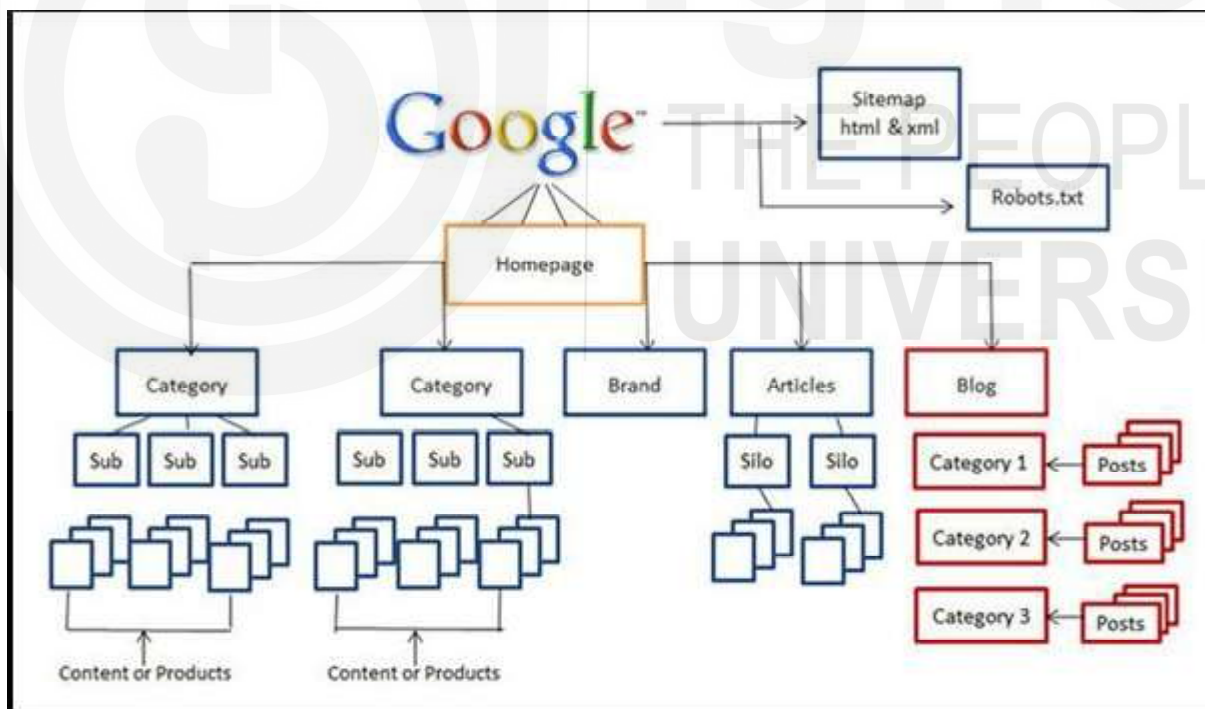
12.8 NAVIGATION AND SITE DESIGN

If content is the heart of every website, navigation is its brain and both are the basic pillars of website designing. If you are providing a large quantity of content, the critical importance of navigation cannot be undermined. If users are unable to reach out to the desired content it means there is lot of input cost but with zero output value.

The navigation of a website allows visitors to access information from page to page provided in the website. Navigation system of a website should be easy and user friendly. Many designers tend to try several things to make their website different from others but many a times it becomes a puzzle for the users. Website navigation menu should look like navigation and the matter should be located where users are expecting it. This is the simple basic philosophy of website designing. While designing navigation system of a website the designer needs to take following things into consideration.

12.8.1 Design for the Reader

The fundamental principal of website designing is that it should be designed keeping the readers in mind. Avoid designing navigation simply for it to look good. Try to involve readers from the start and seek their feedback regarding the navigation system. Try to use simple and easily understandable navigation names. Do not try to use obscure names that are not commonly understood.



Remember, navigation is supposed to be an aid for the readers. Hence, it must be understood that involving readers throughout on their ease and comfort level in using the navigation system is critical otherwise you will never come to know about the reader's requirement.

12.8.2 Let Readers Know Where They Are

Another important aspect of navigation system is to let reader know where they are. The simple way to do so is to make the tab bold where the reader is navigating.

For example, if reader is on entertainment page, the entertainment tab in masthead should become bold to give the readers clear and unambiguous idea about where they are. For this a website should carry prominent titles for every page. If readers are on any subsection of a section page both the tabs should be designed in a way which would indicate the location clearly to readers.

12.8.3 Let Readers Know Where They Have Been

Yet another a fundamental principal of navigation design is to let readers know where they have been on the website. This is the reason why you see that majority of content in the website is in HTML form. It makes it possible to give readers an idea about where they have been on the website. The HTML links which have been clicked become purple and the links which have not been clicked remain blue. So the designer should keep two things in mind. First, keep as much navigation as possible in hypertext and second, use blue colour for unclicked and purple for clicked, which is universally in use in website designing.

12.8.4 Let Readers Know Where They Are Going

Navigation should also let readers know where they are going. In most of the cases readers click on a link with an impression that the link is a HTML page but sometimes the content is in PDF or Word format. It can make readers irritated, so while designing navigation let the readers know the kind of content they are going to access in advance. The way to achieve it is to create classifications as self-explanatory as possible. If the content is in PDF format. inform readers before they click the link. Also give them other options to see the content like view as HTML. Navigation system should also let the readers know that whether content is opening in the same window they are operating or in new window. Sometimes it also confuses readers in going to other pages from the new window.

12.8.5 Follow the Web Convention

A number of web conventions have emerged on the web. The designers, who have deliberately avoided these conventions just to look different, may achieve nothing but usually end up confusing their readers. Do not shy away from visiting some popular websites to understand their navigation system. Some classified conventions which have emerged on the web are:

- Global navigation-this refers to navigation that runs at the top and bottom of every web page containing links of the major sections of the website.
- 'Home' is the convention of the overall homepage.
- 'About' contains content describing the history, financial performances, goals and mission of the website.
- 'Contact' or 'contact us' contains contact details of the owner of the website.

12.8.6 Be the Consistent

Readers usually turn to navigation when they are lost and confused. Please do not confuse them further by providing them inconsistent classifications. Consistency in classification is critical for a successful navigation system. Consistency in navigation requires:

- Consistency in navigation

- Consistency in hypertext colour
- Consistency in graphic navigation design.

12.8.7 Provide the Reader Support and Feedback

In a website, readers should be only a click away from being able to contact the organization. Contact facility may involve email, phone numbers, call back facility or customer chat facility. This will not only satisfy your users but will also provide you many ideas to further improve your website. Do not mislead your readers by providing them contact details they cannot use. Many websites provide 'help' button to assist them to perform complex task. Text must be used in a comprehensive way to inform the readers about the result of their action.

Check Your Progress: 6

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Describe global navigation.

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12.9 LET US SUM UP

In this Unit we have discussed the skills required for content creation for news websites, blog content and content for mobile communication. We have also discussed the basics of video production for web news and audio for web.

We have come to know about the basics of flash journalism production techniques. We have also learnt about navigation and the skills required for site design

12.10 KEYWORDS

Flash Journalism : is online style of narrating a news story in which many media elements are combined, and it addresses primarily two issues of internet field - packaging different media elements into one, secondly it is compatible to diverse platforms. It enhances the reach of multimedia based news delivery.

IVR : or Interactive Voice Response System is an automated phone answering system in which a pre- designed programme interacts with the caller based on inputs provided through voice or keypad.

WEBSITE Navigation: is a kind of signage board or road map in your website to guide your users to navigate various pages. Hyperlinks in a webpage facilitates the easy navigation within and outside of a particular website.

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12.12 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress: 1

- 1) In order to bring scanability to the story in the content of news websites, online writers can use facilities such as:

- Give bulleted information.
 - Highlight important keywords.
 - Use images without hesitation.
 - Use tables and brief profiles.
- 2) Tags improve functional interactivity of site. The words used in the end of the web story are tags. When one clicks those words it brings one onto a web page carrying all the related stories to the tags. It improves functional interactivity and credibility of the website.

Keywords improve Search Engine Optimisation (SEO) to the content which means the possibility of the content to feature in searches of Users. The search engine picks up keywords of the story. In CMS (Content Management System) journalists have an option to add additional keywords to the story

Check Your Progress: 2

Personal blogging is blogger centric. It means one can write in it whenever and whatever he/she wants. In personal blogging bloggers have freedom to choose topics. It is seen that in these types of blogs, often the bloggers tend to write about their personal opinions which may be highly subjective and hence biased also. Generally bloggers choose topics which have surfaced in the mainstream media and try to give in their own opinion on the topic. Following code and conduct of any organisation and professional ethics is not necessary in personal blogging.

A professional blog, however, is reader centric. Here as a blog writer, one does not have the liberty to write according to his/her interest. One has to keep his/her readers in mind while deciding even the topic. That usually means an ultra-focused topic at regular intervals.

Check Your Progress: 3

- 1) IVR is a technology that allows a computer to interact with humans through the use of voice. IVR systems can respond with pre-recorded or dynamically recorded audio to further assist users as to how to proceed.

Check Your Progress: 4

- 1) A podcast is a media file (usually audio or video) that is available for download via syndication. By subscribing to the podcast feed, each new instalment of podcast is directly delivered to the computer to be played back as per convenience. Many news websites use this facility to add expert views as an audio podcast to the story.

Check Your Progress: 5

- 1) Flash is a multimedia platform used to add animation, video and interactivity to web pages. Flash manipulates graphics to provide animation of text, drawings and still images. It supports bidirectional streaming of audio and video. It can capture user input via camera, mouse and keyboard. It has object oriented language called Action Script.

Check Your Progress: 6

- 1) Global navigation refers to navigation that runs at the top and bottom of every web page containing links of the major sections of the website.

UNIT 13 PRODUCTION OF NEWS WEBSITE

Structure

- 13.0 Introduction
- 13.1 Learning Outcomes
- 13.2 Basics of News Website Management
 - 13.2.1 Website Operations
 - 13.2.2 Characteristics of News Website
- 13.3 Types and Methods of Website Creation
 - 13.3.1 Through HTML
 - 13.3.2 Through Content Management Systems
 - 13.3.3 Alternative Methods
- 13.4 Creating News Website - HTML Method
- 13.5 Creating News Website - CMS Method
- 13.6 Alternative Methods of News Website Creation
 - 13.6.1 Using Word Processing Applications
 - 13.6.2 Using Open Source Website Builder
 - 13.6.3 Using Commercial Software
- 13.7 Let Us Sum Up
- 13.8 Keywords
- 13.9 References and Further Readings
- 13.10 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

13.0 INTRODUCTION

Newer technologies adopted brought with them changes into the news packaging and delivery systems. We have witnessed dramatic audio-video based news delivery in the last century – the major one being ‘LIVE’ broadcasts. Also the Information and Communication Technologies (ICT) have made a significant impact bringing about fundamental changes in the news delivery, especially to the online news consumption. Presently, news website have become common to all existing newspapers, radio stations, television news channels, news agencies and even many online only news websites and portals as well. The quantum of operations of various news websites, however, differ from one another and depends on the type of news organisation.

In this Unit, we shall be learning about how to design a news website. ICT tools do provide multiple options for any individual or a news organisation to design and develop a news website. We shall study three methods which are discussed in detail in this unit - 1] using coding method i.e. with the help of HTML coding. This is the basic fundamental approach and by practicing this method, you can be familiar with the basic news website operations. Since any online news website requires a plethora of facilities, all of them may not be possible to be created only through HTML. 2] using content management system (CMS) i.e. with the help of open source CMS. This is an advanced method and it encompasses most

features and facilities at industry standards. In this, the major task is to customise the CMS according to one's requirement. 3] Other than coding and CMS, there are few other alternative methods to create news websites. By the end of this Unit, you will have a better understanding and sufficient basic knowledge about news website production.

13.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After going through this Unit, you will be able to:

- describe the basic news website operations and its management;
- discuss different methods and techniques of news website production; and
- apply HTML coding to create a basic news website. As well as using open source Content Management System (CMS) create a news website. Also create a news website by using other alternative methods.

13.2 BASICS OF NEWS WEBSITE MANAGEMENT

You must have got a broad idea as you went through Units in the Course on Reporting and Writing wherein details about the fundamentals of news and its production process were given. News organizations receive news stories from multiple sources - mainly through their own correspondents and stringers but also through national and international news agencies, and from news syndicates. And basic news collection is more or less common in any newsroom setup—whether it is newspaper, radio or TV. Online news websites also follow the same methods to collect its raw material — that is news stories. However, the presentation and packaging of news stories differs in each medium. Newspaper is print and photograph oriented, radio is audio format, and television is audio-visual mode. And the online news-websites encompass all the different media elements — text, picture, sound, video and animation. Hence it is a multimedia based news packaging and presentation platform. In this Unit, we shall focus more on packaging and presentation of news stories in a news website.

13.2.1 Website Operations

Basically, the website is similar to a folder in a computer which contains numerous files. This computer is called a web-server, which is connected into a network that is known as World Wide Web. In order to access the folder and its files, there is an address attached to each folder which is referred to as the Uniform Resource Locator (URL). For example, the URL for IGNOU is [http:// www.ignou.ac.in](http://www.ignou.ac.in). Each folder in the web-server computer is password protected and can be accessed for adding or deleting files only with the password. Normally only the 'Admin' is allowed to control and manage these folders however same folder can be accessed and viewed by everyone. Generally, the folder on the web-server contains a file called index, and by default whenever some user visits this URL to access this folder, the Home page opens automatically. It is that page which displays all relevant information and links to the remaining pages and files. Admins of various folders/websites, use File Transfer Protocol (FTP) methods to upload and download the files and folders for the website administration.

13.2.2 Characteristics of a News Website

All news websites have adopted the general convention of style used for newspapers in their packaging and presentation of news stories. Hence, you might have noticed that newspapers always use a white background and black text and coloured text only in specific contexts. The same approach is being highly recommended for news websites — text of news stories in black with a white background.

Similar to newspaper columns, web pages of news websites also have multiple grids /columns. In the Home page as well as in the main section pages, news stories are placed in a multiple grid format. And in the individual news story pages — it is recommended to have three grids, left side grid consists of basic links of news website, while news stories go into the middle grid and relevant links/stories and other links are placed in the last grid. Inverted pyramid style which is the unwritten convention for writing a news stories, is the same applicable to news websites also. Lengthy stories may be broken into multiple stories or if that is not possible, the same story may be packaged into multiple pages. As online users generally tend to scroll less, it is a practice to convert news stories into two basic components — the primary component usually contains the headline and intro, while the secondary component contains the remaining content of the news story.

Navigation within the website should be maintained with a consistent style. Appropriate keywords or tags need to be attached with the news stories to assist in categorisation of news stories and to facilitate searching for the news story within the website and through search engines in order to fetch most relevant results. The white spaces should be utilized judiciously and consistently throughout the news website. Suitable space for advertisement may be specified and followed consistently throughout in all the webpages.

In addition to the above mentioned aesthetic characteristics, there are a few technical features that are being recommended for a news website: 1] make sure that the news website can be loaded into user's laptop or mobile quickly; 2] relevant keywords, tags and metadata should be used that will make the news website more search engine friendly; 3] integration of social media tools for sharing as well as receiving comments would facilitate higher outreach and most importantly more page views; 4] news website should be mobile ready and friendly with the various types of handsets; 5] depending upon financial resources — content management system and Apps are highly recommended for a news website.

Check Your Progress: 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) How to register a domain name for a website?

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- 2) Lists four similarities and dissimilarities between a newspaper and a news website?

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- 3) How to make a cross-browser based news website?

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13.3 TYPES AND METHODS OF WEBSITE CREATION

There are many ways in which a webpage (a standalone webpage) or a website (website is a collection of multiple interlinked webpages) can be created. As you are aware, Information and Communication Technology (ICT) tools have been demassified extensively by various interests groups-particularly Creative Commons and Open Source movements. Firstly, there are many commercial softwares available in the market dedicated specifically for a website design; secondly, there are other commercial softwares that are meant for some other utilities which can be used to add additional features in the website. In addition to these commercial softwares, there are many open source packages available to carry out similar works. Thirdly, creating a webpage or website through a coding process. Coding and programming for website design is a complicated process and it requires different set of coding and programming. However, in this Unit, we shall restrict ourselves to introduce only HTML coding for the purpose of creating a functional news website.

13.3.1 Through HTML

Hyper Text Markup Language (HTML) was first written by Tim Berners-Lee in 1991. HTML is meant for marking up the media elements — text, photograph, animation, and audio-video materials into a structural unit. In simple terms, HTML specifies the characteristics of elements' position and display over the digital system. With the help of Hyper Text Transfer Protocol, media elements are transferred from one computer to many through World Wide Web network.

There are many versions of HTML that existed over a fairly long period of time. Let us have a brief glance of its evolution:

Over a period of time, developments in HTML were its standardisation and universal applications but developments of browsers were introduced later. There are significant differences between early HTML and those used currently-HTML.

The table 1 gives a broad outline of the changes that took place in HTML. Through HTML, individual webpages are created. Once many webpages are ready, they are interlinked resulting in a website. Usually landing page of a website is named as index.html — once user types a particular URL, browser displays the ‘Home’ page.

Table 1

Type of Content	HTML	HTML 4.01	HTML5
Heading	Yes	Yes	Yes
Paragraph	Yes	Yes	Yes
Address	Yes	Yes	Yes
Anchor	Yes	Yes	Yes
List	Yes	Yes	Yes
Image	Yes	Yes	Yes
Table	No	Yes	Yes
Style	No	Yes	Yes
Script	No	Yes	Yes
Audio	No	No	Yes
Video	No	No	Yes
Canvas	No	No	Yes

13.3.2 Through Content Management Systems

If a news website generates fewer news stories in a day, then it would be easier for it to create and maintain the website through HTML mode. Otherwise, if news website handles a large number of news stories, for example a national or state level newspaper that manages the online news portal, then website management becomes an enormous exercise. And a small web team might not be able to handle its operations e.g., producing around 500 webpages in a day is a mammoth job. In this context, a technical solution is required. Content Management System (CMS) is the solution to handle large volumes of online news operations. There are many commercial CMSs available to handle it and an equally large number of open source CMSs are used extensively by various news organisations across the country. Some of the popular CMSs are - Wordpress, Drupal, Joomla!, TYPO3, Square space, Magnolia and so on

The main advantages of using CMS for a news website are:

- content and website design are separated, so it is easy to change site design easily;
- large number of open source CMSs are updated frequently as these packages are supported by a community of developers. They contribute substantially and regularly to the improvements of CMS by way of plug- ins and widgets;
- CMS is developed by a company or a group of developers, and the CMS always meets compliance of latest technical standards of web and internet; and

- CMS provides seamless workflow by which works are assigned to many persons that facilitates better coordination and collaboration among many different individuals.

13.3.3 Alternative Methods

Using word processing applications, such as Microsoft Word (proprietary software) or Open Office word processor (Free and Open Source software), a webpage/website can be created. This is a non-technical approach of creating a news website. Whatever materials are typed/inserted in the word processor would be converted into a .html file. Multiple files can be interlinked using hyperlink options, thus creating a complete website.

Though it is may be easy to create a website without knowing any technicality of HTML coding or CMS techniques, however it will have its own inherent disadvantages. Usually a word processor software is meant for pages and its print outcomes. Hence, the page orientations of these software are meant for page sizes e.g. A4 or legal. But webpages have different dimensions. This incompatibility may create imbalance in the website design.

Check Your Progress: 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Name three methods of website production.

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2) Trace briefly the history of HTML coding.

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3) List differences between proprietary and open source software.

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13.4 CREATING NEWS WEBSITE – HTML METHOD

In this segment, you will learn the basic HTML markups to create a news website. HTML is a combination of ‘tags’ within which required display content needs to be nested. In the first stage, let's learn about the basic tags-

<DOCTYPE html> - as mentioned earlier in 15.3.1, the current version is HTML5. This tag is not a HTML tag, but it informs the respective web browsers that this HTML document is written in HTML 5.

<html> - it is a root element in a webpage.

<head> - it contains metadata information about the webpage

<title> - title of the document is specified here

<body> - display content is nested within this tag

b - for headlines

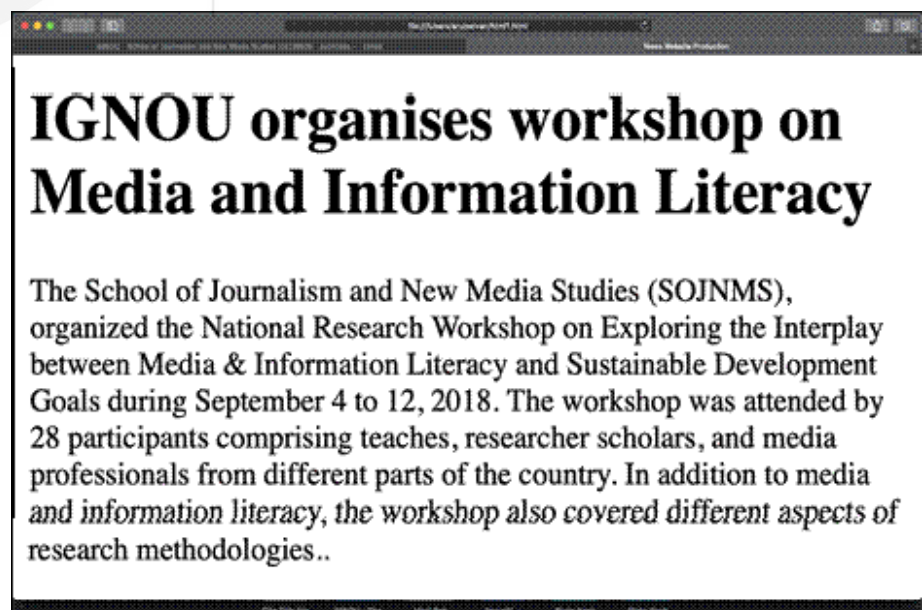
<p> - for paragraphs

Let us start building a basic webpage for a story:

Creating a basic webpage:

Follow these instructions in Notepad.

- 1) **Open** software applications => **Notepad**.
- 2) In the new document, type the following HTML tags.
- 3) After typing all HTML tags along with the required content, this document needs to be saved as a webpage.
- 4) In the Notepad, click Save As option under File menu. Dialogue box will appear, in that type required onlinejour.html and filetype should be selected as All Files.
- 5) Location of the above file should be in a new folder.



- 6) Now open the folder, you can see onlinejour.html. Open this file in a browser, and you can see only the headline and a paragraph.

```
<DOCTYPE html>
```

```
<html>
```

```
<head>
```

```
<title>News Website Production</title>
```

```
</head>
```

```
<body>
```

```
<h1>IGNOU organizes workshop on Media and Information Literacy</h1>
```

```
<p>The School of Journalism and New Media Studies (SOJNMS), organised the National Research Workshop on Exploring the Interplay between Media & Information Literacy and Sustainable Development Goals during September 4–12, 2018. The workshop was attended by 28 participants comprising teachers, researcher scholars, and media professionals from different parts of the country. In addition to media and information literacy, the workshop also covered different aspects of research methodologies.</p>
```

```
</body>
```

```
</html>
```

Adding full story and colours:

We will continue to work on onlinejour.html. It is a basic webpage, now we will add full story and we will insert colours to the text.

- 1) **Open** onlinejour.html in Notepad and continue editing.
- 2) The remaining content of the story is added with the help of <p> tag.
- 3) These are basic text formatting tags - **Bold**, <i>Italics</i>, <u>underline</u>
- 4) Colours to the text are added by inserting this attribute to the respective HTML tag style= “color:green;”, in this file this attribute has been added to the headline (within <h1>) and to the resource persons (within).
- 5) After adding all tags for colours, open onlinejour.html file in a browser and check it.

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
```

```
<html>
```

```
<head>
```

```
<title>News Website Production</title>
```

```
</head> <body>
```

```
<h1 style=”color:red;”>IGNOU organizes workshop on Media and Information Literacy</h1>
```

```
<p>The School of Journalism and New Media Studies (SOJNMS), organised the National Research Workshop on Exploring the Interplay between Media & Information Literacy and Sustainable Development Goals during September 4–12, 2018. The workshop was attended by 28 participants comprising teachers, researcher scholars, and media professionals from different parts of the country. In addition to media and information literacy, the workshop also covered different aspects of research methodologies.</p>
```

```
<p><b style=”color:green;”>Prof. Nageshwar Rao, Vice Chancellor, IGNOU,
```

in his inaugural address stressed the role of different media especially social media in the present context as mobile has enabled media's reach to everyone with simple tap or a touch. He argued that despite information deluge consumer of information is smart enough to separate wheat from the chaff.

Prof. Jagtar Singh, Punjabi University, Patiala was the Guest of Honour who emphasized the role of MIL role in empowering the citizens to make informed decisions. MIL is essential to enables people to derive full benefits of the fundamental human rights and freedoms as well as enable sound social discourse.

Director, SOJNMS Prof. Shambhu Nath Singh in his welcome address said that the workshop is extremely useful as it would delve upon the various facets of media including content, dissemination and consumption.

Dr. K. S. Arul Selvan of SOJNMS, Workshop Coordinator in his introductory remarks defined Media and Information Literacy (MIL) as an ability to access, analyze, and create media to realise the rights to freedom of information and expression.

Prof J. S. Yadav, former Director, IIMC, stressed the need for a holistic approach for doing research in Sustainable Development Goals.

Adding images:

Before adding images to a webpage, the following points need to be kept in mind.

Image should be in a compressed mode, that would enable faster downloading and taking less time to display in the user's screen.

Image file should be available in the same folder where html file is stored.

- 1) HTML tag to insert a image - ``
- 2) To resize image, you can specify its width and height - ``
- 3) Due to any technical difficulty, if the image is not displayed in the user's computer then a brief information about the image can be conveyed through 'alt' tag - ``
- 4) Whenever we insert image, it creates a line break. In order to avoid white space, image should be wrapped around text. To place image wrap around text, use this tag 'align' and it has attribute of 'left' and 'right' - ``
- 5) Images are generally placed inside the news story, in order to give a space between image and text, use 'hspace' tag with numeric attribute - ``

- 6) If image has been sourced from the web, then use URL of image location for source - ``

Adding Links

In the above step we have created a webpage with text and an image. Similarly, if we repeat for five more different stories, we will end with six independent webpages. The main characteristics of online medium is interactivity and with the help of hypertext - interlinking webpages that makes website and interlinking many websites create a network called World Wide Web.

- 1) To create a link within your folder/website - `<a href="university.html">IGNOU</a>`
- 2) To create a link with outside your website, use full URL including http:// - `<a href="http://www.ignou.ac.in">IGNOU</a>`
- 3) To create a link using a image - `<a href="university.html">IGNOU</a>`

Once hyperlink is created with text of image, it turns into blue color with underline and when mouse pointer is moved over it turned into hand symbol.

Adding Table

Now we have created a raw webpage and this needs to be complete in all respects. Particularly, it should carry the name of the website, details about the website, other news sections and services the website offers. To incorporate all these details at the same time, the news stories also should be visible along with these details. For this, we need to divide the page into number of columns and rows, by inserting table into the page. Each cell will hold all these details including news stories.

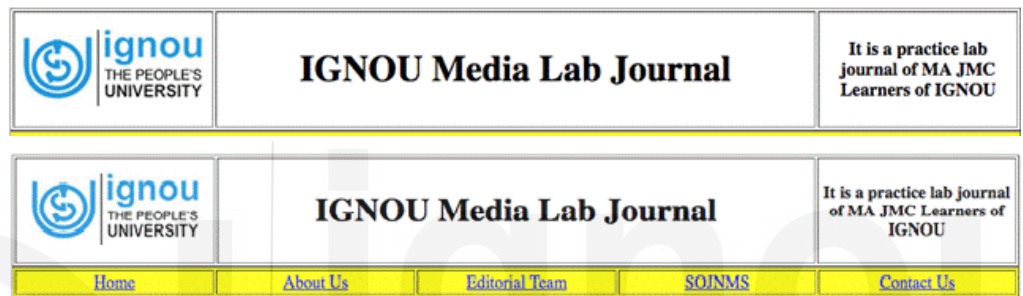
- 1) There are three important HTML tags for creating a table - `<table>`, `<tr>` for row and `<td>` for column.
- 2) Using our onlinejour.html file, on the top of news story we will insert a website name, a logo and a brief about the website. Since, there are three


```
<table width="100%" border="1" style="border-collapse: separate; border-spacing: 2px;">
<tr>
<td width="20%" align="center"></td>
<td width="60%" align="center"><h1 style="color:blue";>IGNOU Media Lab Journal</h1></td>
<td width="20%" align="center"><h4>It is a practice lab journal of MA JMC Learners of IGNOU</h4></td>
</tr>
</table>
```
- 3) In the same file, just below the website title, we shall insert a table that contains details about the lab journal website:

```

<table width="100%" border="1" bgcolor="yellow" style="border-collapse:
separate; border-spacing: 2px;">
<tr>
<td width="20%" align="center"><a href="index.html">Home</a></td>
<td width="20%" align="center"><a href="aboutus.html">About Us</a></td>
<td width="20%" align="center"><a href="editorial.html">Editorial Team</a></
td>
<td width="20%" align="center"><a href="http://ignou.ac.in/ignou/aboutignou/
school/sojnms/introduction">SOJNMS</a></td>
<td width="20%" align="center"><a href="contact.html">Contact Us</a></td>
</tr></table>

```



Now we shall divide the news story segment into three columns - first one contains links to major news categories, second column contains news stories and third column contains other news stories of category in which page story belongs.

```

<!DOCTYPE html>
<html>
<head>
<title>News Website Production</title>
</head>
<body>
<table width="100%" border="1" style="border-collapse: separate; border-
spacing: 2px;">
<tr>
<td width="20%" align="center"></td>
<td width="60%" align="center"><h1 style="color:blue">IGNOU Media Lab
Journal</h1></td>
<td width="20%" align="center"><h3>It is a practice lab journal of MA JMC
Learners of IGNOU</h3></td>
</tr>
</table>
<table width="100%" border="1" bgcolor="yellow" style="border-collapse:
separate; border-spacing: 2px;">
<tr>

```



```

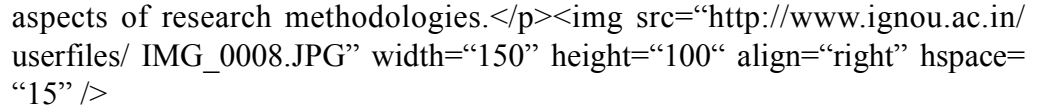
<td width="20%" align="center"><a href="index.html">Home</a></td>
<td width="20%" align="center"><a href="aboutus.html">About Us</a></td>
<td width="20%" align="center"><a href="editorial.html">Editorial Team</a></td>
<td width="20%" align="center"><a href="http://ignou.ac.in/ignou/aboutignou/school/sojnms/introduction">SOJNMS</a></td>
<td width="20%" align="center"><a href="contact.html">Contact Us</a></td>
</tr>
</table>

<table width="100%" border="1" style="border-collapse: separate; border-spacing: 5px;">
<tr>
<td valign="top">
<table width="100%" border="1" bgcolor="grey" style="border-collapse: separate; border-spacing: 2px;">
<tr>
<td align="center"><a href="politics.html">Political News</a></td></tr>
<tr>
<td align="center"><a href="city.html">City News</a></td></tr>
<tr>
<td align="center"><a href="devnews.html">Development News</a></td></tr>
<tr>
<td align="center"><a href="health.html">Health News</a></td></tr>
</table>
</td>
<td width="60%" valign="top" style="padding:5px">

```


IGNOU organises workshop on Media and Information Literacy

The School of Journalism and New Media Studies (SOJNMS), organized the National Research Workshop on Exploring the Interplay between Media & Information Literacy and Sustainable Development Goals during September 4-12, 2018. The workshop was attended by 28 participants comprising teachers, researcher scholars, and media professionals from different parts of the country. In addition to media and information literacy, the workshop also covered different aspects of research methodologies.



Prof. Nageshwar Rao, Vice Chancellor, <http://www.ignou.ac.in> IGNOU, in his inaugural address stressed the role of different media especially social media in the present context as mobile has enabled media's reach to everyone with simple tap or a touch. He argued that despite information deluge consumer of information is smart enough to separate wheat from the chaff.

Prof. Jagtar Singh, Punjabi University, Patiala was the Guest of Honour who emphasised the role of MIL role in empowering the citizens to make informed decisions. MIL is essential to enable people to derive full benefits of the fundamental human rights and freedoms as well as enable sound social discourse.

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Prof J. S. Yadav, former Director, IIMC, stressed the need for a holistic approach for doing research in Sustainable Development Goals.

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Other Stories in this Section

First News

Second News

Third News

```

<tr><td align="center"><a href="news4.html">Fourth News</a></td></tr>
</table>
</td>
</tr>
</table>
</body>
</html>

```

Creating a Complete News Website

Now we have created a webpage for a single story. In this similar manner, individual pages will be produced using new and different stories. Based on number of stories, that many number of webpages will be created.

Once webpages for all news stories are created (keeping it remember that all html files and its associated images have to be kept in a single folder), we need to have two more pages that will combine all stories into categories and all categories into home page.

HTML code for Home page:

```

<!DOCTYPE html>
<html>
<head>
<title>News Website Production</title>
</head>
<body>
<table width="100%" border="1" style="border-collapse: separate; border-
spacing: 2px;">
<tr>
<td width="20%" align="center"></td>
<td width="60%" align="center"><h1 style="color:blue";>IGNOU Media Lab
Journal<h1></td>
<td width="20%" align="center"><h4>It is a practice lab journal of MA JMC
Learners of IGNOU</h4></td>
</tr>
</table>
<table width="100%" border="1" bgcolor="yellow" style="border-collapse:
separate; border-spacing: 2px;">
<tr>
<td width="20%" align="center"><a href="index.html">Home</a></td>
<td width="20%" align="center"><a href="aboutus.html">About Us</a></td>
<td width="20%" align="center"><a href="editorial.html">Editorial Team</a></

```

```

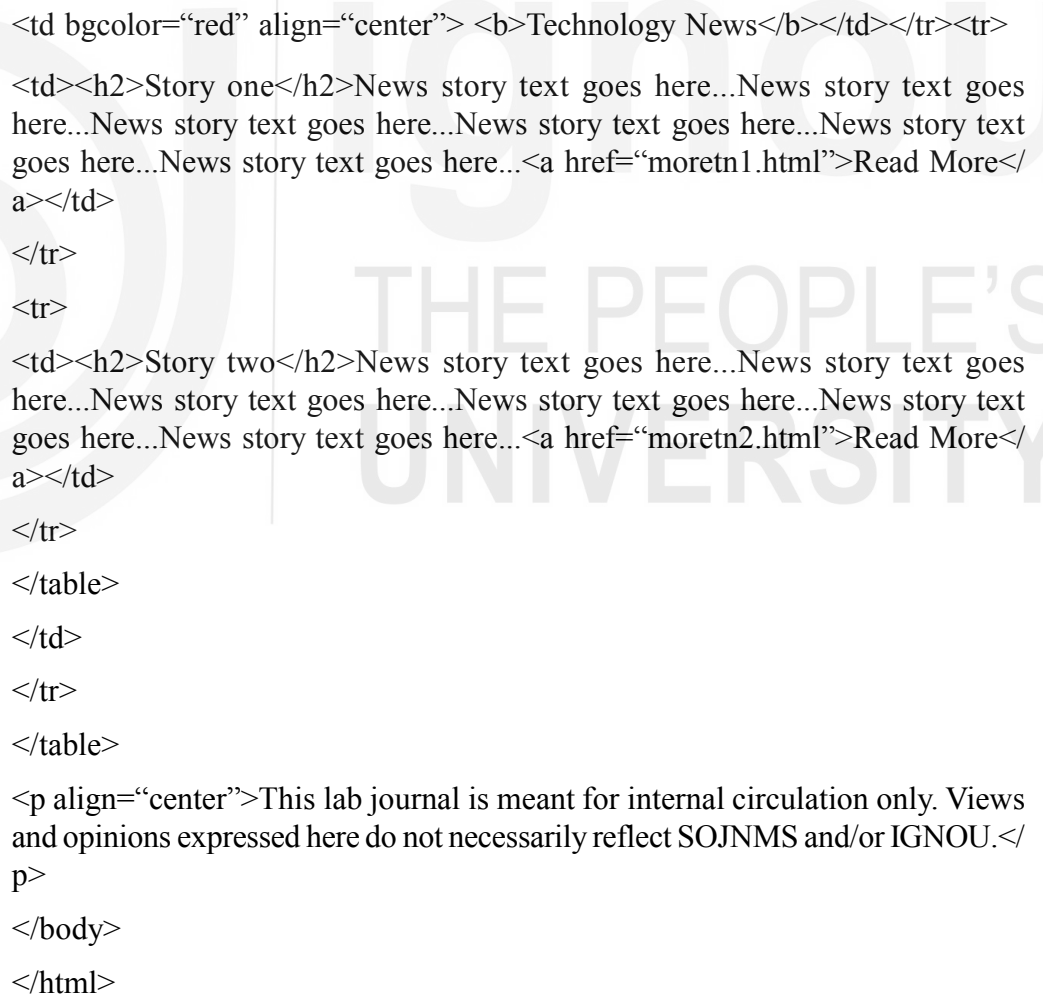
td>
<td width="20%" align="center"><a href="http://ignou.ac.in/ignou/aboutignou/
school/sojnms/introduction">SOJNMS</a></td>
<td width="20%" align="center"><a href="contact.html">Contact Us</a></td>
</tr>
</table>
<table width="100%" border="1" style="border-collapse: separate; border-
spacing: 5px;">
<tr>
<td width="35%" valign="top" style="padding:5px">
<table>
<tr>
<td bgcolor="red" align="center"><b> Political News</b></td></tr><tr>
<td><h2>Story one</h2>News story text goes here...News story text goes
here...News story text goes here...News story text goes here...News story text
goes here...News story text goes here...<a href="morepn1.html">Read More</
a></td>
</tr>
<tr>
<td><h2>Story two</h2>News story text goes here...News story text goes
here...News story text goes here...News story text goes here...News story text
goes here...News story text goes here...<a href="morepn2.html">Read More</
a></td>
</tr>
<tr>
<td bgcolor="red" align="center"> <b>Health News</b></td></tr><tr>
<td><h2>Story one</h2>News story text goes here...News story text goes
here...News story text goes here...News story text goes here...News story text
goes here...News story text goes here...<a href="morehn1.html">Read More</
a></td>
</tr>
<tr>
<td><h2>Story two</h2>News story text goes here...News story text goes
here...News story text goes here...News story text goes here...News story text
goes here...News story text goes here...<a href="morehn2.html">Read More</
a></td>
</tr>
</table>
</td>
<td width="35%" valign="top" style="padding:5px">
<table>

```

```

<tr>
<td bgcolor="red" align="center"> <b>City News</b></td></tr><tr>
<td><h2>Story one</h2>News story text goes here...News story text goes
here...News story text goes here...News story text goes here...News story text
goes here...News story text goes here...<a href="morecn1.html">Read More</
a></td>
</tr>
<tr>
<td><h2>Story two</h2>News story text goes here...News story text goes
here...News story text goes here...News story text goes here...News story text
goes here...News story text goes here...<a href="morecn2.html">Read More</
a></td>
</tr>
<tr>
<td bgcolor="red" align="center"> <b>Weather News</b></td></tr><tr>
<td><h2>Story one</h2>News story text goes here...News story text goes
here...News story text goes here...News story text goes here...News story text
goes here...News story text goes here...<a href="morewn1.html">Read More</
a></td>
</tr>
<tr>
<td><h2>Story two</h2>News story text goes here...News story text goes
here...News story text goes here...News story text goes here...News story text
goes here...News story text goes here...<a href="morewn2.html">Read More</
a></td>
</tr>
</table>
</td>
<td width="30%" valign="top">
<table>
<tr>
<td bgcolor="red" align="center"> <b>Sports News</b></td></tr><tr>
<td><h2>Story one</h2>News story text goes here...News story text goes
here...News story text goes here...News story text goes here...News story text
goes here...News story text goes here...<a href="moresn1.html">Read More</
a></td>
</tr>
<tr>
<td><h2>Story two</h2>News story text goes here...News story text goes
here...News story text goes here...News story text goes here...News story text
goes here...News story text goes here...<a href="moresn2.html">Read More</
a></td>

```



Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) List seven primary HTML tags.

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2) How to create a link by using an image?

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3) What is the role <table> tag in a website design?

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13.5 CREATING NEWS WEBSITE - CMS METHOD

Content Management System based news website operation is an industry standard. Unlike HTML based website creation, where webpages are created manually but in CMS pages are created automatically with the help of databases. For a news organisation which handles large number of news stories on daily basis, and publishes stories throughout the day means it needs a CMS based news website. To run and manage a CMS based website, the minimum requirement is a web server and then a package of CMS. Due to open source movements, a good number of packages are available free of cost to experiment the creating a website.

Creating CMS based website is quiet technical, besides HTML one needs to be have a basic understanding of other high level programming languages such as PHP, SQL in order to customise the CMS for specific requirements. However, for learning purposes, the learners of this course can try localhost (intranet) option. In the localhost option, you can convert your computing devices (personal computer/laptop) into a web server with the help of an open source package called XAMPP. XAMPP is acronym for X-Platform independent, A-Apache

server, M-MariaDB (database), PHP and Perl (both are server side scripting languages). XAMPP packages are available in this URL- <https://www.apachefriends.org/index.html>. A detailed descriptions of how to install XAMPP is available in this link (as on 2019) - <https://www.wikihow.com/Install-XAMPP-for-Windows>.

Once XAMPP is installed (take enough precautions, and consult professional help before installing XAMPP), your system effectively converted into a web server. You can check your web server by typing this link in your browser- <http://localhost>. It will show you the details of XAMPP.

Since web server is available, now you need to choose a CMS to create a website. As on 2019, an open source package called Wordpress is a popular CMS, interested learners may try to test wordpress based news website on their own - suitable precautions may be taken. Wordpress CMS is available for free of cost under open source license in this link - <https://wordpress.org/download/>. A detailed instructions for installation of wordpress is available in this link - <https://www.wikihow.com/Install-Wordpress-on-XAMPP>

Popular news website in India - www.indianexpress.com, is using wordpress CMS for its website. This organisation is extensively customized wordpress CMS for their news operations. Screenshot (taken in 2019) of their site is given on previous page.

Check Your Progress: 4

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Expand the abbreviation XAMPP.

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2) Lists four benefits for running a news website based on a CMS.

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13.6 ALTERNATIVE METHODS OF NEWS WEBSITE CREATION

13.6.1 Using Word Processing Applications

With the help of regular word processors, a document can be converted into a webpage. Here there is no technicality involved, once the word document is ready and same may be saved as a webpage. Use File -> Save As -> Webpage. In this way, your document will be saved as an html file. In order to make it as a

website, include all necessary hypertext in every webpage. It will make all webpages interlinked and your website will be complete.

All major word processors (Commercial Software: Microsoft Word, Apple Pages. Open Source Software: OpenOffice and Libreoffice) are supporting this html file format options.

13.6.2 Using Open Source Website Builder

There are good number of open source free HTML editors available. Unlike normal text based software like Notepad, which we used in this Unit to create HTML codes, these advanced HTML editors are professional in nature. It supports html coding generation like syntax highlighting, auto-completion and provides comprehensive Integrated Development Environment (IDE).

One of the HTML open source advanced editor is Bluefish (which is available for download in Windows or Mac operation system in this link - <http://bluefish.openoffice.nl/index.html>), which provides a seamless environment to create HTML coding for your website.

13.6.3 Using Commercial Software

Like Bluefish open source software, equally a good number of commercial HTML editors are available. One of the popular commercial software for HTML editor is Adobe Dreamweaver. Like Bluefish it gives syntax checking, code completion and IDE. Besides these features, it has a unique live preview option that enables visualisation of webpage and more creative. There are three view pane options - Code view, Design view and Split Code view. In code view, it shows only HTML codes and appropriate editing is carried out here with relevant HTML codes, in design view - it is like a word, all contents are included using menu

```
Bluefish /Users/arulselvan/Desktop/unit5/onlinejour.html 1/4
1  <!DOCTYPE html>
2  <html>
3  <head>
4    <title>News Website Production</title>
5  </head>
6  <body>
7    <table width="100%" border="1" style="border-collapse: separate; border-
8      spacing: 2px;">
9      <tr>
10         <td width="20%" align="center"></td>
12         <td width="60%" align="center"><h1>
13           style="color: blue">IGNOU Media Lab Journal</h1>
14         <td width="20%" align="center"><h4>It is a practice lab
15           Journal of MA JMC Learners of IGNOU</h4></td>
16       </tr>
17     </table>
18     <table width="100%" border="1" bgcolor="yellow" style="border-collapse:
19       separate; border-spacing: 2px;">
20       <tr>
21         <td width="20%" align="center"><a href="index.html">Home</a></td>
22         <td width="20%" align="center"><a href="aboutus.html">About Us</a></td>
23         <td width="20%" align="center"><a href="editorial.html">Editorial Team</
24         a></td>
25         <td width="20%" align="center"><a href="http://ignou.ac.in/ignou/
26         aboutignou/school/sojnms/introduction">SOJNMS</a></td>
27         <td width="20%" align="center"><a href="contact.html">Contact Us</a></td>
28       </tr>
29     </table>
30     <table width="100%" border="1" style="border-collapse: separate; border-
31       spacing: 5px;">
32       <tr>
33         <td width="35%" valign="top" style="padding: 5px">
34         <table>
35         <tr>
36         <td bgcolor="red" align="center"><b> Political News</b></td></tr><tr>
37         <td><h2>Story one</h2>News story text goes here...News story text goes
38
```


based tools. In split code view, web page can be designed using either HTML code or menu based tools or both. Along with these features, Dreamweaver provide Mobile design and compatibility features. From Dreamweaver, using its FTP options you can directly control your web server folder - including uploading and downloading website files.



Check Your Progress: 5

Note: 1) Use the space below for writing your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) What are the benefits of using an advanced HTML editor?

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2) Compare and contrast between a normal text editor (Notepad) and an advanced HTML editor.

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13.7 LET US SUM UP

In this Unit, we have learnt the basics of website creation, characteristics of a news website and different methods of creating a news website. We have learnt that a web server is required to run a website along with a domain name. Once we get domain name and its is attached with the your web server folder, it gives a Universal Resource Locator (URL) - that is the web address of your news

website. News websites closely follow major characteristics of offline newspapers - predominantly white background and black text, not much cluttering of the whitespace with colours and distractive elements and news stories should be presented in a scannable way along with using multiple media elements.

We have learnt four different methods through which we can create a news website. 1] using HTML coding; 2] by CMS method; 3] with help of word processors; 4] through advanced HTML editors (Open source and Commercial software). All these methods vary in terms of technicality and difficulties.

13.8 KEYWORDS

Content Management System : Content management system (CMS) is a server side scripting mechanism in which two components (website content and website design) of a website is combined independently and displayed it as a single component on the user's devices.

HTML: Hyper Text Markup Language is a computer coding through which individual webpages are created by including various media elements such as text, graphics, sound, video, and hyperlinks.

HTML EDITOR: is a tool for creating and editing code in hypertext markup language.

WEBSITE : According to Merriam Webster dictionary the term website is defined as, "a group of World Wide Web pages usually containing hyperlinks to each other and made available online by an individual, company, educational institution, government, or organisation."

13.9 REFERENCES AND FURTHER READINGS

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13.10 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress: 1

- 1) Technically website is a folder which is stored in a web server that is connected to internet. In order to reach this particular folder, domain names are assigned. There are diverse level of domain names, popular ones are - .com, .in, .co.in, .ac.in, .edu, .net, .org. To get a domain name, one should use approved domain registry. Upon registration, DNS details should be mapped with the web server hosting entity. Once mapping is done, the website will be visible to everyone across the browser.
- 2) Printed newspapers are mobile, versatile, convenient to read and easy to carry. Online newspaper is digital presentation of news stories using various technological tools, it reaches nook and corner of the world, it uses hypertext to interlink and expand a news stories to backgrounders at ease and no limit of space crunch.
- 3) Use a simple design, avoid a heavy media contents, always use percentages while specifying width of a table, use unicode fonts, insert only compressed standardized photo formats. More specifically cross-check your website in a multiple browsers before uploading.

Check Your Progress: 2

- 1) using HTML coding; b) using content management system; and c) with the help of software
- 2) Hypertext Markup Language was introduced in 1991. It is meant to specify arrangements of media content to the browsers. Over a period of time, various versions were introduced to enhance the utilities of HTML. The current version of HTML is 5, which was introduced in 2014.
- 3) Primarily proprietary is a commercial one, and users need to pay to use this software. These software are controlled by multinational agencies which are meant for profit. Not every user can afford to buy and use the proprietary software. On the other hand, open source software is free and mostly developed by an individual or a group of individuals (communities). These software are frequently updated to fix the bug or to enhance its utilities and most importantly open source software are easily customizable.

Check Your Progress: 3

- 1) `<html><head><title></title></head><body></body></html>`
- 2) `<a href="aboutus.html"></ a>`
- 3) With the help of HTML tags it is not possible to divide the display area of a website. `<table>` tags are used in order to divide the display area and place an appropriate content.

Check Your Progress: 4

- 1) X-Platform independent, A-Apache server, M-MariaDB (database), PHP and Perl (both are server side scripting languages)
- 2) Content Management System automates a news website by delinking templates of design and news story contents. In this way, there is a consistence across the website. If any changes is required in design, editing design template is sufficient and the same is applied across the broad. CMS creates a unique way of URL for each story, which is compatible with search engines. Adding news stories is just like a writing an email. Content plays a crucial role, technicality is being fixed separately. Many open source CMSs are available and it is easy to customize as per one's requirements.

Check Your Progress: 5

- 1) Website design is a comprehensive exercise. Advanced web design requires multiple coding and scripting support. In an HTML editor, it is easy to switch between codings and scripting. Since each line in the HTML editor is numbered, it enables to identify the errors. Major HTML editors support FTP operations, by which it is easy to manage your websites.
- 2) Unlike normal text based software like Notepad, which we used in this Unit to create HTML codes, these advanced HTML editors are professional in nature. It supports html coding generation like syntax highlighting, auto-completion and provides comprehensive Integrated Development Environment (IDE).

